

PERadoxical Cert-ainty in SNAP: Rethinking the Accuracy-Access Tradeoff

July Spector-Bishop*

August 3, 2026

Abstract

Recent federal policy changes have compelled states to prioritize payment accuracy over access to benefits in the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP). Some states have required participants to recertify more frequently, in order to verify that eligibility and benefit determinations are accurate, but such requirements threaten to reduce program takeup through increasing administrative burdens. I find preliminary evidence that shorter certification periods can have the opposite of their intended effect: increasing the administrative workload faced by state agencies, thus leading to more errors. Using public-use SNAP Quality Control data, I show that eligible non-elderly households are more likely to have a payment error if they certified during a quarter in which state agencies had to process more recertifications. This paper contributes to the sparse literature on the causes of SNAP Payment Error Rates (PER) and re-frames payment accuracy as the output of overall administrative quality rather than one side of an accuracy-access tradeoff.

1 Introduction

Accurately determining eligibility and benefits is a perennial concern for social safety net programs. However, efforts to ensure that benefits only flow to the needy can impose onerous administrative burdens on program recipients. Under this view, policymakers face a choice: do you make it easier to apply and risk overpaying benefits, or do you increase eligibility verification requirements and risk driving the needy away from the program if they can't navigate a sea of paperwork? In the case of the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP), this is sometimes framed as a tradeoff between program participation and the Payment Error Rate (PER), which measures the share of benefits that are later determined to have been mistakenly overpaid or underpaid (Kabbani and Wilde 2003).

Despite the prevalence of this accuracy-access framing, research on this topic has been uneven when it comes to SNAP. For example, recertification, the process through which SNAP recipients must demonstrate continued eligibility in order to maintain benefits, has been shown to act as a barrier to program access (Homonoff and Somerville 2021, Giannella et al. 2024, Gray 2019). However, there has been relatively little work on the effect of SNAP certification periods on payment accuracy, or into the causes of payment accuracy more broadly. The research that exists is decades out of date and primarily demonstrates correlations (Kabbani & Wilde 2003, Mills et al. 2004).

Understanding SNAP payment accuracy has taken on a critical new relevance in recent years. Under the 2025 One Big Beautiful Bill Act (OBBBA), states with PERs above 6% would be required to pay for a fraction of SNAP benefits roughly equal to their PER. Given that the average state PER for FY2025 was 9.82%, this will likely impose significant financial penalties on most states (FNS 2026b). For example, Illinois would be liable for approximately \$705 million annually in SNAP benefits (IDHS 2025). States unable to either

*I would like to thank Professors Matthew Tarduno, Darren Lubotsky, and Benjamin Ost of the University of Illinois at Chicago, Donn Feir of the University of Victoria, Sabrina Young of DePaul University, and Marianne Bitler of the University of California, Davis. I would also like to thank Janet Spector-Bishop, John Bishop, Camille Baker, Addison Keefe, and Kevin Johnson, as well as all the SNAP recipients, caseworkers, and policymakers who helped inform this paper.

afford this price tag or reduce their PER may be forced to withdraw from SNAP, potentially threatening the food security for tens of millions of Americans.

This change incentivizes states to prioritize accuracy over access, leading them to adopt policies which risk jeopardizing access to SNAP for many of the neediest Americans. For example, Illinois shortened its SNAP certification periods from 12 to 6 months (IDH 2025) in order to more frequently verify that recipients are indeed eligible and that their benefit allotments are accurate. However, the lack of research on this topic means that it's unclear whether these efforts will be effective at reducing PER. Recertification has been shown to impose significant administrative burdens on participants, causing substantial erroneous disenrollment of eligible households (Gray 2019, Homonoff and Somerville 2021) and possibly reducing program participation (Mills et al. 2004). Thus, the decision to require more frequent recertification will likely increase these impacts for recipients.

The effect that shorter certification periods will have on state agencies is less clear, but it will likely significantly increase the workload of state SNAP agencies. While there has been much discussion of the ways in which policies may impose administrative burdens for safety net program participants (Fox et al. 2023, Giannella et al. 2024, Herd & Moynihan 2019), there has been little consideration of the burdens faced by administrators. What is clear is that certifying and recertifying cases is financially costly, constituting the primary category of SNAP administrative spending by states (Geller et al. 2019). Additionally, a significant fraction of the eligible households who lose benefits through recertification successfully reapply to SNAP within a few months (Homonoff and Somerville 2021), in a process known as "churn". Processing these reapplications costs states much more in terms of financial and personnel resources than if these households had been correctly recertified (Mills et al. 2014). Thus, multiplying the frequency of recertification may also multiply the associated administrative workload and financial costs faced by state agencies.

For this reason, it seems just as plausible that a policy of shorter certification periods could worsen SNAP PER, rather than improve it, by straining state administrative capacity. About 57% of payment errors in fiscal year 2023 are attributed to mistakes made by state agencies (FNS 2025), with 58% of errors occurring during recertification. SNAP recertifications are processed by human case workers, who will have less time to check a client's information for errors the more recertifications that they have to process per day.

In this paper I examine the effect of SNAP certification periods on PER using the public-use SNAP Quality Control (QC) data for FY2022-2024. I use an instrumental variable (IV) approach to test the hypothesis that shorter certification periods can worsen payment accuracy to the degree that they increase administrative workload. I use the average certification periods assigned to different subsets of SNAP cases as an instrument for the share of a state's caseload that recertifies in a given quarter, which I use as a proxy for that administrative workload faced by state agencies. I use this to estimate the treatment effect that this workload has on several measures of payment accuracy among eligible SNAP cases.

I find preliminary evidence that shorter certification periods can increase the administrative workload faced by state agencies, thus leading to more errors. Eligible non-elderly households are more likely to have a payment error if they certified during a quarter in which state agencies had to process more recertifications. My results suggest that decreasing the certification period assigned to elderly/disabled households from 24 to 12 months would increase the quarterly share of cases recertifying by 6.25 percentage points. This would cause the PER among eligible non-elderly households to increase by 1.9 percentage points, relative to an average quarterly PER of 5.7% for this group. However, these results are not robust across specifications, and a number of econometric limitations must be resolved before they can be taken at face value. Additionally administrative spillovers are only one way in which changing a state's certification period might affect their PER. The net treatment effect may run in the opposite direction if the other mechanisms dominate.

This paper makes several contributions. Firstly, it is the first paper in almost 20 years to examine the relationship between certification periods and payment accuracy in SNAP. It is the first to causally identify the effect of recertification workload on SNAP PER among eligible SNAP cases, and considers the role that certification period length may play in contributing to this workload. This contributes to the extremely small

literature on factors and policies causing SNAP payment errors. A better understanding of PER is crucial, as states seek strategies for reducing their PER in response to recent federal policy changes. Secondly, I contribute to the public administration literature on safety net programs by considering the administrative burdens faced by workers at state agencies, which has gone relatively understudied.

Thirdly, I argue that, in the case of SNAP, the focus on the accuracy-takeup tradeoff may be misplaced. While such a tradeoff likely exists in many contexts, it explains relatively little of the variation in payment accuracy or program participation in SNAP. Instead, I argue that other factors, such as overall administrative quality, are likely more relevant to most states interested in improving their PER.

2 Background and Setting

The Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) is the largest federal means tested near-cash public assistance program in the United States, and is intended to help low income households afford food through providing monthly food vouchers. It differs from other major cash and near-cash assistance programs in that it is available to individuals regardless of family structure, disability, or age. Benefit amounts primarily depend on income and household size. As of FY 2025, it provided \$ 96 billion in benefits to 42 million monthly recipients (FNS 2026c).

The benefits allotted to a household are calculated based on the household’s size, income, and a number of deductions. This allotment can become incorrect if a household’s circumstances change, or if they become ineligible. Thus, households that successfully apply for SNAP are only certified to receive benefits for a specific length of time, after which they must recertify. While the specifics can vary, recertification typically involves an interview with a caseworker and submitting documentation relevant to program eligibility and benefit amounts. States enjoy broad discretion over how they assign certification periods, up to 12 months for most households, and up to 24 or 36 months for households in which all members are either elderly or disabled. The most common certification periods in my data (covering FY2022-FY2024) were 6, 12, 24, and 36 months. Depending on their certification period, households are also required to report information to state agencies between recertifications. The most common interim reporting regime is simplified reporting. While the specifics can vary between states, households assigned to simplified reporting are only required to report interim changes that would make them ineligible for SNAP based on their gross income (Fannin 2025).

SNAP is jointly run by the federal and state governments. Broad program rules defining eligibility and benefit amounts flow from the Food and Nutrition Services (FNS) of the US Department of Agriculture (USDA), while state human-services agencies performed the work of actually determining eligibility of applicants and calculating their benefit allotments. Since 1996, the federal government has paid for 100% of benefits, and 50% of most administrative costs, while states made up the other half.

This administrative and funding structure potentially creates a principal-agent problem where states have little incentive to avoid over-issuing benefits, or issuing benefits to the ineligible, while Uncle Sam foots the bill. The SNAP Quality Control (QC) system was created to address this. Each annual QC review randomly selects a sample of active SNAP cases in each state, totaling approximately 50,000 cases. QC reviewers at state agencies intensively audit these cases, seeking to fully verify participant information and identifying payment errors based on criteria set down by the FNS. Then, federal QC reviewers re-audit approximately half of these cases and calculate an annual Payment Error Rate (PER) for each state. Finally, FNS penalizes states based on their performance, levying \$102 million in liabilities in FY2023 on states with high PER (FNS 2025), thus incentivising them to improve.

The One Big Beautiful Bill Act (OBBBA), signed July 4, 2025, changes SNAP’s federal-state balance. Starting in FY2028, states with a PER above 6% will have to pay for a fraction of SNAP benefits roughly proportional to their PER in either FY2025 or FY2026, depending on which year a state chooses (Feeding America 2026, Ward 2025). Based on the PER figures from FY2025, 37 states and territories would be

required to pay for a share of benefits. This will likely impose significant financial penalties on many of these states, and will mark the first time in the program’s history that states would be required to pay for a portion of benefits. Among many other changes to SNAP, the OBBBA also cuts federal reimbursement for state administrative expenses from 50% to 25%, leaving states to cover the gap.

Proponents of these changes argue that these measures are necessary to ensure that states have sufficient “skin in the game” through a “modest state sharing component, so that they’ll pay attention to that, so that we can reduce fraud” (Johnson, 2025). For context, the USDA emphatically states that PER is not a measure of fraud, and that most payment errors occur due to administrative errors on the part of state agencies (FNS 2025, USDA 2025). Critics of this new policy contend that it sets states up to fail by demanding better outcomes on short deadlines with fewer administrative resources. They argue that the existing system of fines already incentivized payment accuracy and that the real goal of the policy is to reduce SNAP caseloads by leaving states with no choice but to either adopt more burdensome eligibility screening or to withdraw from SNAP entirely (Bergh and Rosenbaum 2026, FRAC 2025). There is one point of clear agreement between these two perspectives: the OBBBA puts immense and unprecedented pressure on states to lower their PER.

Understanding and addressing the causes of PER requires some technical understanding of how it is calculated, as well as its history. The national PER for FY2025 was 10.6%, with state PER varying from Alaska’s 23.15% to Idaho’s 3.85% (FNS 2026b). PER has risen dramatically since the pandemic, the national PER peaking at 11.7% in FY2023, compared to 7.4% in FY2019¹. A state’s annual PER represents the dollar amount of benefits that the state issued in error, as a fraction of all SNAP benefits issued in that state. A payment error occurs when a state underissues SNAP benefits to a participating household, overissues SNAP benefits to a participating household, or issues benefits to an ineligible household. The official PER is the sum of two components: the overpayment PER and underpayment PER. While the full FNS methodology for both PER components is complex, it can be roughly characterized as an adjusted the ratio of average under/overpayments per case to the average allotments issued per case (7 CFR 275.23(b))²

If a household is ruled ineligible by QC reviewers then its entire benefit amount is counted as being in error, and counted as overpayment. Additionally, for each eligible case, QC reviewers calculate the correct benefit amount for the month reviewed based on the information obtained in their audit. The difference between this amount and the actual benefits issued is only counted as a payment error if it is greater than a specific tolerance threshold set by FNS and adjusted annually. For FY2024 this threshold was \$56. Thus, a case whose benefit amount in the reviewed month is off by \$56 or less is counted as having a payment error of 0, and a case with benefits off by \$57 is counted as having a payment error of \$57. These can either be an overpayment or an underpayment.

3 Literature and Contribution

3.1 Past Literature

The accuracy-access tradeoff is a defining feature of the conversation surrounding PER, and thus one cannot discuss the literature on PER without also discussing the literature on program access and administrative burden. Kabbani and Wilde (2003) argue that “caseload declines [are] one dimension of a tradeoff states may have faced between encouraging program participation and lowering QC error rates”. This framing remains prominent in the literature to this day (Fannin 2025). Under this view, state SNAP policymakers must balance the conflicting needs to both thoroughly verify that accurate benefit amounts are only paid to eligible households, and also to ensure that paperwork and verification requirements aren’t so onerous that they prevent the needy from obtaining benefits.

¹Draft Note: Do I need to individually cite the data release from each year?

²The ratio is adjusted based on the difference between state and federal QC findings, state completion rate and methodology, and state SE. See federal regulations for more details.

For example, during the late 1990's, the QC system created financial incentives for states to reduce their PER (Kabbani and Wilde 2003). Agencies responded to this by implementing short certification periods (≤ 3 months) for working families in order to more frequently verify that recipients were still eligible and that their benefit allotments accurately reflected their current circumstances. However, Kabbani and Wilde (2003) argue that this came at the expense of program participation because recertification creates a significant compliance cost for participants. The risk of program exit is much higher during recertification (Ribar et al. 2008). Several papers find that as many as half of these households likely remained eligible (Gray 2019, Homonoff and Somerville 2021, Mills et al. 2014), with the first two of these papers providing strong quasi-experimental evidence that such program exits are substantially caused by administrative burden³. Requiring more frequent recertification would mechanically multiply the impacts of these burdens.

No study has definitively identified the effect that these short certification policies had on PER or program participation. Kabbani and Wilde 2003 use a two-way fixed effects model to estimate that a 10 percentage point increase in the use of short certification periods (3 months or less) is associated with a .6-.81 percentage point reduction in PER, and a 2.6-2.7% decline in participation. This finding aligns with Mills et al. 2004, whose simulations show a modest but inconsistent association between shorter certification periods and lower errors, but much steeper declines in participation. Logan et al 2008 find an association between short certification periods and lower errors, though their results are difficult to interpret. Several other papers also document an association between the use of short certification periods and a decline in program participation in the late 90's and early 2000's (Currie and Grogger 2001, Kornfeld 2002). While helpful, these papers provide suggestive evidence at best, as most have serious methodological limitations and none of them causally identified the treatment effect of short certifications. Additionally, it is worth mentioning that only Kabbani and Wilde 2003 was published in a peer reviewed journal, with the others being reports from government agencies or think tanks. Taken together, existing research indicates that, to the extent that short certification periods can be linked to reduced errors, the associated reduction in program participation is possibly much larger.

Concern over the participation impacts of short certification periods led to a number of reforms under the 2002 Farm Bill, and many states transitioned from a system of short certification periods to one of long certification periods and simplified reporting (Hanratty 2006, Logan et al. 2008). In this, it is worth emphasizing the degree to which certification periods and interim-reporting regimes can be thought of as inextricably interrelated policies (Trippe et al. 2004). Several 2WFE papers find that this switch to longer certification periods increased participation, but do not find an effect from simplified reporting (Hanratty 2006, Ratcliffe et al. 2008), while the overall package of simplification reforms reduced measures of error by 2.5-4.4 percentage points (Logan et al. 2008). Ribar et al. 2008's simulation indicates that abandoning short certification periods mechanically increased caseloads in South Carolina. In qualitative interviews, agency staff say that the combination of simplified reporting and longer certification periods improved program access for participants, while simplified reporting helped reduce PER (Trippe et al 2004).

Taken together, existing empirical research does not provide definitive evidence that an accuracy-access tradeoff actually exists in the case of SNAP certification periods. Such a tradeoff would require that shorter certification periods cause lower payment errors and lower program participation, all else equal. Instead, the research on certification period length only provides us with suggestive evidence that they might be associated with PER, though the evidence on program participation is slightly stronger. Additionally, more frequent verification of eligibility and benefits is only one channel through which certification periods might affect PER, and, as I argue in the Data section, there may be other countervailing channels.

Unfortunately for states seeking strategies to reduce their PER in response to the OBBBA, past research probably doesn't tell us very much about how certification periods affect payment accuracy in 2026. Between automatic data matching, online applications, the rollout of EBT, and many other changes, the practicalities of administering and interacting with SNAP are dramatically different from when those papers were written.

³Clarifying terminology: In this literature, the term "administrative burden" refers to the psychological, compliance, and learning costs that a program imposes on its recipients (Herd & Moynihan 2019). I use the term "administrative workload" to refer to the burdens faces by state agency workers in the course of administering the program.

The PER measure itself has changed to a degree that what was true of it in the 90’s may no longer be true today⁴. The present study builds on this previous work as the first paper in almost 20 years to examine the relationship between certification periods and payment accuracy in SNAP, and by being the first to causally identify part of this relationship⁵.

What does seem clear is that much of the variation in PER seems to be explained by changes to the measurement itself, or to how it is measured. A 2015 OIG report and subsequent investigation found that 42 out of 53 states were systematically, and often intentionally, under-reporting SNAP payment errors in order to receive QC performance bonuses (USDA, OIG 2015, FNS 2021). This ultimately resulted in substantial reforms to the QC process, as well as Department of Justice settlements against eight states that were found to be violating federal law (FNS 2023). This may explain why national PER rose by 70% between FY2014 and FY2017 (FNS 2026a). Additionally, while simplified reporting policies have been found to reduce PER, much of this effect is likely attributable to the fact that it causes fewer things to technically count as errors for the purpose of calculating PER (Fanin 2025, Logan et al. 2008, USDA 2005, Trippe et al. 2004.). Of relevance to the present policy context, a CBPP report argues that much of the post-pandemic increase in PER is an artifact caused by changes to how the QC process defines errors, and that these changes artificially inflate the overpayment rate (Rosenbaum and Bergh 2024). Beginning in FY2022, a household was automatically determined to be ineligible for the purposes of PER if its certification period had expired, or if it failed to complete certain QC forms, regardless of whether it was actually eligible (FNS 2022). It is plausible that this change explains the recent rise in PER, given that the fraction of ineligible cases in the QC rose from 1.9% in FY2017-2019 to 3.7% in FY2022-2024 (based on the QC technical documentation).

3.2 Reframing

In the context of the accuracy-access tradeoff, policymakers can be thought of as occupying a production possibility frontier (PPF) between these two program outcomes. A state’s position along this PPF reflects differences in state policy preferences between being generous but inaccurate (type 1 error) or accurate to the point of screening needy families out of the program (type 2 error). This framing, and the overlapping take-up vs targeting tradeoff, are common in discussions of safety net policy and likely exists on the margin of many policy contexts (Finkelstein and Notowidigdo 2019). However, this framework’s relevance to the present study hinges on how much of the variation in SNAP PER it actually explains, and how much is better explained by other factors.

There is reason to believe that it does not explain SNAP PER very well. To see this, consider the neighboring western states Nevada and Utah, which have similar climates, population densities, and population distributions. One area where they do differ greatly is in their residents’ access to SNAP. In Utah, only about four in ten households below 125% of the Federal Poverty Line (FPL) receive SNAP, while in Nevada more than nine in ten do. This is despite the fact they are similar in two of their other SNAP performance metrics. They both have lower than average PER of 6.6% and 5.8% respectively (national average was 11.3%), and they both process about 94% of SNAP applications within 30 days of receiving them (Application Processing Timeliness APT).

These two states are part of a broader pattern shown in figure 1a: that if there is a PPF style tradeoff between payment accuracy and generosity, then it is a remarkably flat one. Among the 10 states with the lowest average PER for FY2022-2024 (shown orange), the Program Access Index (PAI)⁶ has a range of 58.75 percentage points. Additionally, the marginal tradeoff between these outcomes is somewhat moot for states operating well interior to the PPF, as it is possible for them to improve both. This suggests that accuracy and access may not necessarily be an either-or choice in practice.

⁴Draft Notes: This paragraph is about external validity. Do I need to use the word "external validity"?

⁵A 2025 conference paper by Issar, Valizadeh, Bryant, and Fischer finds some preliminary evidence that 7-12 month certification periods may be heterogeneously associated with overpayments in FY2003-2019. They also find simplified reporting and vehicle exclusion rules may be associated with lower overpayments.

⁶The USDA’s PAI measures the SNAP participation rate among households below 125% of the FPL

The rest of figure 1 further undermines the practical relevance of the accuracy-access tradeoff to explaining PER. A state operating on the PPF faces a tradeoff between false positives, represented by PER, and false negatives, partially represented by the USDA's Case and Procedural Error Rate (CAPER), which measures the improper denial of benefits to eligible households. Contrary to the inverse relationship that this would imply, figure 1b indicates that states which perform well on one metric also tend to perform well on the other. Of the 27 states/territories with an above median PER (avg of 2022-2024), 19 of them had above median CAPER. Similarly, if a state agency is intent on lowering its PER we might expect it to process applications more slowly, sacrificing its Application Processing Timeliness (APT) metric in favor of thoroughness. Instead, figure 1c shows that states with low PER tend to also process applications quickly.

It is important to point out that the literature's characterization of PER as a measure of false positives is misleading (Kabbani and Wilde 2003), as it is the sum of both overpayments and underpayments. If one focuses on the choice between excessive generosity and burdensome restrictiveness then one would expect these two types of payment errors to be inversely related, exhibiting their own sort of PPF. However, figure 1d demonstrates the opposite: states that avoid issuing too few benefits also tend to avoid mistakenly over-issuing benefits.

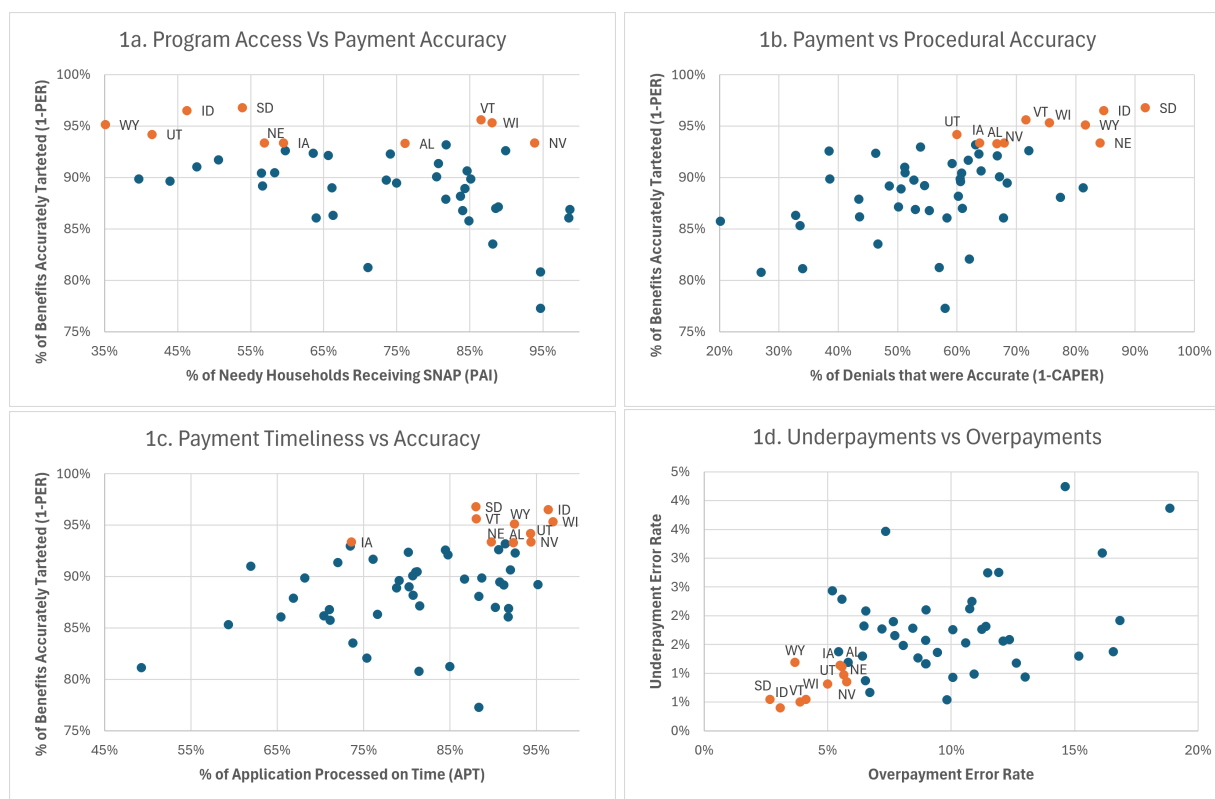


Figure 1: Avg. state level SNAP performance metrics for FY2022-2024. The 10 states with the lowest PER are in orange. 1a shows the relationship between program access (Program Access Index PAI: participation rate among households below 125% of FPL) vs SNAP payment accuracy. 1b shows the relationship between the accuracy of SNAP payments and the accuracy of benefit denials (1- the Case Procedural Error Rate CAPER). 1c shows the relationship between Application Processing Timeliness (APT) and PER. 1d shows the relationships between the underpayment and overpayment components of PER. Graphs exclude Alaska for the sake of readability.

Given this evidence, I propose that PER might be better understood as an output of overall state administrative quality than as one side of an accuracy-access tradeoff. Furthermore, the administrative workload faced by a state SNAP agency is likely a key factor in shaping its administrative quality. About 57% of payment errors in fiscal year 2023 are attributed to mistakes made by state agencies (FNS 2025), with 58% of errors occurring during recertification. SNAP recertifications are processed by human case work-

ers, who will have less time to check a client’s information for errors the more recertifications that they have to process per day. This aligns with the limited evidence from state agencies, who cite high staff turnover, job vacancies, burnout, and high workload at state agencies as the major factors contributing to PER (APHSA, 2023)⁷, while staff report that the workload reduction from simplified reporting and longer certification periods likely helped reduce PER (Trippe et al. 2004). Based on this, we would expect that anything that increased the ratio of administrative workload to agency resources would also increase PER. This is somewhat undercut by a supplemental analysis in Geller et al. 2019, which does not find an association between state administrative spending and PER. However, they also show that state administrative spending is largely idiosyncratic (driven by fixed effects), with different state agencies likely employing very different production functions, and so this is not a direct measure of the marginal relationship between administrative spending and PER. Thus, the role of administration in SNAP payment accuracy is not yet clear.

Mechanically, the work required to interview and process the recertification paperwork for a household will be doubled if that household is made to recertify twice as often, thus theoretically increasing PER. In terms of administrative resources, certification is very costly, constituting the primary category of SNAP administrative spending by states (Geller et al. 2019). These costs are exacerbated by ”churn”, the phenomena where cases that fail to recertify will successfully reapply within 90 days. Processing these reapplications costs states much more in terms of financial and personnel resources than if these households had been correctly recertified (Homonoff and Somerville 2021, Mills et al. 2014). Churn appears to be a common problem, with 17% to 28% of SNAP households experiencing a churn spell in FY2011 (Mills et al. 2014), and San Francisco County’s having a churn rate of 23.7% in 2014-2016 (Homonoff and Somerville 2021). If households are required to recertify more often then they will be disenrolled more often (Ribar et al. 2008), and thus reapply more often. Taken together, this means that shorter certification periods will increase the workload faced by caseworkers and administrative staff at state agencies, potentially causing them to make more mistakes⁸. Thus, it is possible that state efforts to reduce PER through shorter certification periods may be counterproductive.

Stated the other way around, longer certification periods could potentially offer states a win-win, improving both program access and payment accuracy. This possibility, and the role of administration in PER more generally, has not been considered by previous research. The present paper attempts to fill this gap by examining the effect of SNAP certification period length on PER through it’s impact on state administrative workload. In particular, I hypothesize that adopting shorter certification periods will increase staff workload, straining administrative resources, and that this will increase PER.

I do wish clarify a point of caution. There are likely myriad factors which affect PER, with administrative quality being only one of them. Additionally, the role of administration is likely highly contextual. The ways that states administer SNAP are heterogeneous, and thus different factors are likely to be important for different states. For example, if a state agency is well funded and well staffed then the workload caused by recertification policies might not be particularly impactful. I also wish to make clear that I do not categorically reject the accuracy-access tradeoff. It seems conceptually sensible and probably exists in many contexts and across many margins of safety net program design. My point in this reframing is simply that administrative quality may be a better lens for understanding and improving PER in the present moment.

4 Data

I use the public-use SNAP Quality Control Database for FY2022-2024⁹ as my primary data source because the QC is the primary microdata from which PER is derived, and because it provides a highly detailed

⁷I informally spoke to a number of SNAP caseworkers, who also highlighted these as major factors.

⁸**Draft Notes: I want to do a future study on whether this workload can drive staff turnover, further degrading administrative quality.**

⁹FNS significantly revised the criteria for classifying payment errors in 2021 (Rosenbaum and Bergh 2023). Because of this, post-2021 payment errors may constitute a fundamentally different measure from pre-2021 payment errors. For this reason, I restrict my period of analysis to after the pandemic.

repeated crosssection of SNAP participants. The official state by year PER figures provide insufficient power for meaningful analysis. Instead, I perform my primary analysis on an aggregate state-by-quarter dataset with quarterly PER, which I construct from the FY2022-2024 QC public-use files. Additionally, I perform supplemental analysis at the SNAP case level using the QC data for those years.

Lack of data is a key challenge in studying PER. Unfortunately, the public-use version of the QC is primarily intended to be used as a snapshot of the eligible SNAP caseload. Thus, cases determined to be ineligible by QC reviewers are excluded from the public use data (Leftin et al. 2024). This makes it difficult to use the public use data to study PER, as these ineligible cases make up the vast majority of dollar payment errors (about 75.4% of payment errors in FY2023).¹⁰ For this reason, I restrict my causal estimation to explaining the types of errors fully visible in the QC: underpayments and overpayments to eligible households. For reasons described below, I split my dataset into multiple groups of cases based on case characteristics and consider payment accuracy separately in each group.

Out of 130,058 initial SNAP cases, I dropped 101 cases because they were excluded from the official error rate calculation ($CASE \neq 1$), most of which were in Minnesota in FY2024. A further 61 cases were dropped due to missing key certification variables (missing ACTNTYPE or RCNTACTN). I also drop all cases in Delaware and Guam due to serious data quality concerns. The resulting case level dataset contains 128,051 SNAP cases. For the state-quarter dataset I further drop all quarters for Alaska and New Jersey in FY2024, as their official PER diverged too greatly from what could be replicated from the public use data. Finally, the state-quarter data excludes Alaska, Rhode Island, and the District of Columbia for 2022 quarter 3, as they were missing most or all months from those quarters. The resulting state-quarter dataset contains 601 state-quarters, across 3 fiscal years and 51 states and territories.

For my unemployment rate control, I use the unadjusted state level unemployment rate series from the Bureau of Labor Statistics' Local Area Unemployment Statistics (LAUS). I obtained the LAUS data for the Virgin Islands from the U.S. Virgin Islands Department of Labor. For the state-quarter level dataset, I used the unemployment rate for the middle month of the relevant quarter (February, May, August, November).

I obtained the state implementation dates for the Elderly Simplified Application Project (ESAP) by having Claude search the internet and state records for information on state ESAP adoption. I then manually reviewed its sources and corrected its findings¹¹. Finally, I crosschecked the resulting list of implementation dates against the State Options Reports (Benvie et al. 2023, FNS 2018, McConnell et al. 2024, McConnell et al. 2025) and validated any inconsistencies. I was only able to obtain an approximate ESAP implementation date for the District of Columbia.

¹⁰ According to the QC technical documentation for 2023 (Table II.3)(Leftin et al. 2024), an average of \$661 million in benefits were issued to ineligible cases each month, which totals to \$7,931.6 million for FY2023. Page 15 of the FY2023 QC annual report (FNS 2025) shows that total overpayments and underpayments were \$10,515.9 million for that year. Dividing the former number by the latter indicates that benefits to ineligible households constitute very roughly 75.4% of payment errors in FY2023.

¹¹ **Draft Note: How should I properly list all the sources that I used for this data collection process?**

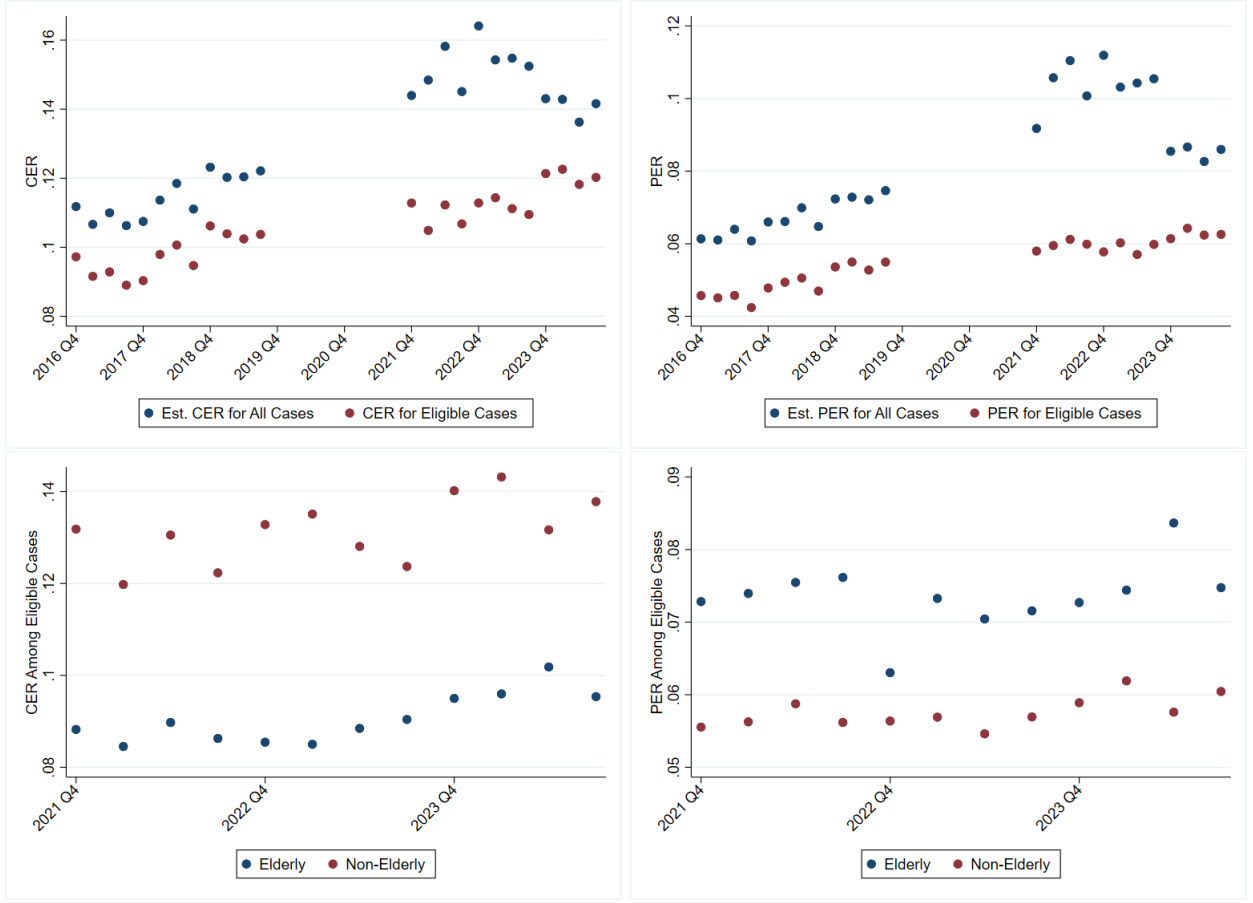


Figure 2: Payment Error Rates and Case Error Rates Over Time

In order to reflect the methodology of the official PER calculation, I define a SNAP case as having a payment error if the dollar amount by which its benefits were in error (AMTERR) was greater than the USDA's tolerance threshold for that fiscal year. For example, cases from fiscal year 2024 are considered to have a payment error if their benefit amount was off by more than \$56 (Leftin et al. 2026). Thus, for the case level dataset, my outcome variables are a binary indicator for whether an individual case has a payment error, and the inflation adjusted dollar amount said payment error ¹².

In the state-quarter level dataset, I calculate separate observable over/underpayment error rates, and overall PER for each group. Ineligible and other dropped cases are excluded from the group level calculations because I cannot observe which group they were a part of. For each group g I construct a PER measure:

$$\text{Underpayment Error Rate}_{sqg} = \frac{\text{Total Observed Underpayments in Group}_{sqg}}{\text{Total Observed Allotments in Group}_{sqg}}$$

$$\text{Overpayment Error Rate}_{sqg} = \frac{\text{Total Observed Overpayments in Group}_{sqg}}{\text{Total Observed Allotments in Group}_{sqg}}$$

$$\text{PER}_{sqg} = \text{Underpayment Error Rate}_{sqg} + \text{Overpayment Error Rate}_{sqg}$$

This group level PER measure only directly provides information on the observed types of errors, not the overall payment error rates within these groups, which would include payments to ineligible households. This is a serious limitation, given that such cases make up the bulk of dollar errors. However, ineligible cases

¹²Insert explanation of how I adjusted for inflation

make up a much smaller share of the cases with payment errors, constituting only 25.3% of errors in the QC data from the states and years studied¹³. Thus, I construct a group level Case Error Rate (CER) in order to better estimate the effects of administrative spillover on the probability of payment errors. This measures the fraction of observed cases in each group which had a payment error.

$$\text{Underpayment Case Error Rate}_{sqq} = \frac{\text{N. Observed Cases in Group with Underpayments}_{sqq}}{\text{N. Observed Cases in Group in QC Dataset}_{sqq}}$$

$$\text{Overpayment Case Error Rate}_{sqq} = \frac{\text{N. Observed Cases in Group with Overpayments}_{sqq}}{\text{N. Observed Cases in Group in QC Dataset}_{sqq}}$$

$$\text{CER}_{sqq} = \text{Underpayment Case Error Rate}_{sqq} + \text{Overpayment Case Error Rate}_{sqq}$$

A lack of sufficiently detailed and publicly available measures of administrative workload within SNAP agencies poses a further challenge to assessing the administrative workload hypothesis. Instead, I use the fraction of cases recertifying in a given quarter as a proxy for workload. Certification and recertification of SNAP cases make up the primary work performed by SNAP agencies and constitutes the bulk of their operational spending (Geller et al. 2019). Thus, variation in the share of cases facing recertification at a given time represents variation in the work of performing recertification interviews and processing the related paperwork. The fraction of cases facing recertification is mechanically determined by the frequency with which cases are required to recertify, and is thus driven by state and federal policies regarding which certification period lengths are assigned to whom.

Ideally I would be able to use variation in state policies in order to identify variation in the share of cases recertifying. However, at time of writing, there exists no dataset which comprehensively tracks such policies over time¹⁴. Instead, I use the certification period lengths observed in the QC data. However, variation in observed certification periods is not exogenous to the effect of administrative workload on PER for several reasons.

Firstly, certification periods are not randomly assigned. States have historically designed certification policies to assign shorter certification to cases that are judged as more likely to have changing circumstances which would affect their eligibility and benefit amount (Kabbani and Wilde 2003). Thus, cases with greater perceived risk of payment error are likely to be assigned to shorter certification periods. This selection would bias a naive estimation of the relationship between certification periods and PER.

Secondly, states may choose to shorten certification periods specifically with the intention of reducing their PER (Kabbani and Wilde 2003), as Illinois did in 2025 (IDHS 2025). This would make the decision to shorten certification periods be associated with higher PER, biasing a regression of the causal relationship.

Additionally, certification period lengths likely affect payment accuracy through more than just their affect of administrative quality. It is helpful to conceptualize 3 channels through which shorter certification periods may affect PER. First is the verification channel, through which shorter certification periods may reduce PER by increasing the frequency with which recipient allotments and eligibility are verified and updated. Past research (Gray 2019, Hastings and Shapiro 2018) has shown that SNAP rules are often only functionally enforced upon recertification. The more often a household must submit documentation in order to recertify, the less likely it is that their information and benefit amount are outdated, thus making their allotment more accurate. For this reason, states have sometimes attempted to improve PER by shortening certification periods (Kabbani and Wilde 2003). This mechanism is likely to interact with the details of state interim reporting policies, which govern when and how recipients must report changes during their

¹³Excluding Delaware and Guam, the public use QC data for FY2022-2024 contained 14,595 payment errors. The QC documentation indicates a further 4,941 errors from payments to ineligible cases. This works out to 25.29%.

¹⁴The USDA's SNAP Policy Database does contain variables tracking certification periods. However, these variables are just tabulations of the certification periods observed in the QC data, calculated based on the trailing 6 months. I decided that it was better to use the QC data to construct certification period variables that are better tuned to my identification strategy. Additionally, the database does not contain any observations for the years studied in this paper.

certification periods.

The caseload composition channel is the effect of shorter certification periods on PER through their impact on the composition of the SNAP caseload. For example, cases with earned income are relatively more prone to payment errors due to their circumstances changing more frequently. For this reason, such cases are often assigned to shorter certification periods and, as I discuss in my literature section, this may have partially reduced PER through discouraging participation among this group. However, as I also discussed previously, recertification leads to substantial case closure for all types of cases, not just those with errors (Homonoff and Somerville 2021). Thus, reducing the number of correct cases on SNAP may offset this effect. The picture is further muddled if an individual’s probability of case closure at recertification is not independent of their probability of having an error. Ex ante, the direction of the caseload composition channel is unclear, but it will depend on who is subject of shorter certification periods, and their relative risk of payment errors. Table 1 shows that eligible households where not all members are elderly or disabled have a higher incidence of payment errors and shorter average certification periods, compared to households where all members are elderly or disabled.

Finally, shorter certification periods might increase PER through the administrative spillover channel hypothesized in the previous section. Under this mechanism, conducting more frequent recertification of one group of cases would increase a state SNAP agency’s the workload, leading to more mistakes and higher PER among all types of cases. This is the channel of interest for the present study.

The first and second channels operate through the effect that a case’s own certification period has on it. Meanwhile, the channel of interest operates through the collective impact that the caseload has on state agencies. A case would be affected by this administrative spillover if their own certification period were held fixed and everyone else’s was shortened, all else equal. Thus, I split SNAP cases into two groups and estimate each groups PER based on the certification periods of the other. More precisely, for a given group of cases g , I use the average certification period among all other cases g^{-1} as an instrument for the fraction of cases recertifying, in order to predict the local average treatment effect of recertification workload on the PER for group g .

I define group a (Ga) as all SNAP cases where all members of the household were either elderly (age ≥ 60), disabled, or both. I define group b (Gb) as all SNAP cases where not all members of the household were either elderly or disabled. I refer to these two groups throughout the paper as the elderly and non-elderly groups, and refer to the cases in these groups as elderly and non-elderly cases. These groups have several advantages. Cases are relatively unlikely to intentionally select into one group or the other for reasons of manipulating their certification period, as one cannot alter their age, and cannot easily alter their disability status. While several past studies have considered households with and without earned income, this potentially introduces selection bias if households alter their employment in response to certification policies. Additionally, each group’s certification period is relatively independent of the other’s.

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics by Group for Eligible Cases in QC Sample (FY2022-2024)

	Elderly		Non-Elderly	
	mean	sd	mean	sd
Cases With Payment Errors	0.09	0.29	0.13	0.34
Payment Error Amount (\$)*	12.43	45.23	27.72	91.81
Benefit Amount (\$)*	170.94	111.70	489.67	315.89
Recertified in Qtr. Observed	0.12	0.33	0.19	0.39
Months Since Last Certification	10.14	11.13	4.49	8.18
Assigned Cert. Period	22.67	12.85	10.58	8.10
Assigned to Simplified Reporting	0.57	0.50	0.82	0.39
Had Earned Income	0.05	0.22	0.43	0.49
Had Unearned Income	0.95	0.23	0.38	0.49
Received TANF	0.00	0.03	0.05	0.21
Household (HH) Size	1.07	0.26	2.52	1.61
White Head of HH**	0.57	0.50	0.50	0.50
Black Head of HH**	0.21	0.41	0.25	0.44
Latino/Hispanic Head of HH**	0.07	0.25	0.09	0.29
Fraction of Cases Recertifying (lag)	0.17	0.08	0.17	0.08
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period (lag)	10.52	3.07		
Avg. Elderly Cert. Period (lag)			21.63	7.89
State Unemployment Rate (lag)	0.04	0.02	0.04	0.01
ESAP implemented (lag)	0.35	0.48	0.38	0.48
Quarter Observed (median)	2023, Q2		2023, Q2	
Quarter Certified (median)	2022, Q2		2022, Q4	
Observations	54,098		73,953	

*Dollar amounts are inflation adjusted based on SNAP allotments for FY2024.

**USDA recommends against tabulating race/ethnicity variables due to missing data.

5 Methods

I estimate the causal effect of administrative workload on payment errors among eligible cases in each focal group (elderly vs non-elderly) using an IV regression based on the certification periods of the alternate group. For sake of clarity, I shall describe the estimation in terms of the non-elderly as the focal group and the elderly as the alternate group. The endogenous regressor of interest for all regressions is the fraction of SNAP cases that recertified in a given state-quarter. This represents the overall administrative workload faced by state agencies, and is intended to capture the strain that administrators face as they certify and monitor non-elderly cases (focal group). The excluded instrument is the average certification period among households where all members were elderly/disabled (alternate group) in a given state-quarter. The relevance assumption is that variation in elderly certification periods induces meaningful variation in the fraction of cases recertifying, and the exclusion restriction assumption is that this variation is exogenous to the potential payment accuracy of the non-elderly.

The outcome variables consist of the measures of payment accuracy described in the previous section. SNAP cases are only observed in the QC for a single reference month. The case level outcomes are observed at in the "present" represented by this reference month. Thus, for the state-quarter level dataset, the outcome variables are the $\widehat{CER}_{gsq}$ and $\widehat{PER}_{gsq}$ among the eligible cases in group g which were observed in state s in quarter q . For the case level dataset, the outcomes are binary indicator $Error_{igsq}$ that case i from group g had a payment error, and the inflation adjusted dollar amount $Amount_{igsq}$ of those errors.

Administrative strain would primarily affect PER through the mistakes that workers at an agency make

when certifying a SNAP case. Indeed 68.13% of the payment errors in my dataset occurred during certification, or before certification (meaning that the certification process failed to correct the error)¹⁵. Thus, it is better to use the explanatory variables from the time period in which cases certified, not the time period in which outcomes were observed. Thus, for the state-quarter regressions I lag the instrument, endogenous regressor, and all other covariates to the quarter in which the cases in a group were certified. For the case level regressions, I lag these variables to the quarter in which each individual case was certified.

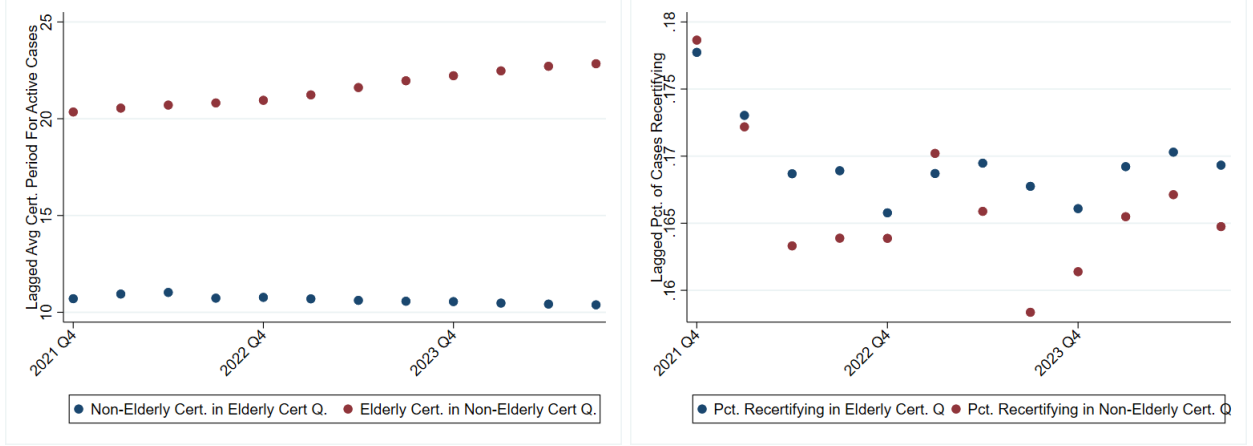


Figure 3: The Instrument and Endogenous Regressor Over Time

For example, my case level endogenous regressor f_{igs} measures the fraction of all cases in state s which recertified during the quarter that case i was certified/recertified. My state-quarter endogenous regressor F_{gsq} is the average fraction of SNAP cases that recertified in state s during all the quarters that the cases in group g (who were observed in quarter q), were certified. Thus, for cases observed in a given quarter, I'm averaging the fraction recertifying in the certification quarter among all of them. For sake of illustration, consider a non-elderly case observed in California in quarter 1 of 2023, but certified in quarter 2 of 2022. For this case I would calculate f_{igs} the fraction of cases in California who recertified in quarter 2 of 2017. Then, for the state-quarter version, I find this fraction for all non-elderly cases observed in California in quarter 1 of 2023, regardless of when they certified, and calculate F_{gsq} as the average of these fractions. Unless stated otherwise, this aggregation procedure is used for all other state-quarter level regressors.

The case level first-stage regression, shown below, estimates the effect of the lagged average certification period among active cases in the alternate group, $c_{g^{-1}is}$, on the fraction of cases that recertified in the quarter that case i recertified, f_{igsq} .

$$f_{igsq} = \alpha_1 + \beta_1 c_{g^{-1}is} + \delta_1 G_{igsq} + \gamma_1 Policy_{gsq} + \eta_1 x_{igsq} + \lambda_s + \tau_q + \epsilon_{sq}$$

Here, λ_s and τ_q are state and quarter fixed effects, $Policy_{gsq}$ represents a set of policy controls discussed below. x_{igsq} is a set of covariates, including: lagged state-quarter level unemployment rate, whether the household contained any children, household size, whether it was a single parent household, whether a case was certified during the pandemic (Q2 2020 - Q4 2021), an indicator for earned income, and an indicator for female head of household¹⁶. Among the non-elderly cases, I also control for whether the household contained any elderly/disabled people.

¹⁵Individual cases might contain multiple errors which might occur at different times. Among cases with payment errors: 57.92% had all error occur during certification, 8.88% had all errors occur before certification, and 1.33% had all errors occur before and during certification.

¹⁶Per Fanin 2025, I do not control for racial/ethnic demographics because the QC technical documentation advises against using them due to a high rate of non-response.

States may decide to simultaneously lengthen or shorten the certification periods for both groups. In this scenario, the certification period for the non-elderly becomes correlated with the instrument. Meanwhile, the effect of their own certification period would affect the payment accuracy among the non-elderly through the verification and caseload composition channels. This would violate the exclusion restriction, biasing the first stage away from 0 and biasing the reduced form towards 0. In order to avoid this, I control for G_{igsq} , the average certification period among active cases in group g who were observed in state s and quarter q . In other words, the average certification period for the elderly is the instrument and the average certification period for the non-elderly is a control.

The state-quarter level first stage is analogously constructed below, where the excluded instrument $C_{g^{-1}sq}$ is the average certification period among active cases in the alternate group in the state-quarters in which the focal group cases certified.

$$F_{gsq} = \alpha_1 + \beta_1 C_{g^{-1}sq} + \delta_1 G_{igsq} + \gamma_1 Policy_{gsq} + \eta_1 X_{gsq} + \lambda_s + \tau_q + \epsilon_{sq}$$

Here, X_{gsq} contains controls for lagged unemployment rate and the fraction of current cases in group g had a female head of household.

Second stage regressions for the case and state-quarter level data are, respectively:

$$y_{igsq} = \beta_2 \hat{f}_{igsq} + \delta_2 G_{igsq} + \gamma_2 Policy_{gsq} + \eta_2 x_{igsq} + \lambda_s + \tau_q + e_{sq}$$

$$Y_{gsq} = \beta_2 \hat{F}_{gsq} + \delta_2 G_{igsq} + \gamma_2 Policy_{gsq} + \eta_2 X_{gsq} + \lambda_s + \tau_q + e_{sq}$$

Where y_{igsq} and Y_{gsq} represent the case and state-quarter level outcome variables.

Policy endogeneity is likely the most serious threat to identification. A state's decision to shorten or lengthen assigned certification periods may be part of a larger package of policy changes which could independently affect PER, recertification rate, or both. Depending on the nature of the policy, this could violate the exclusion restriction or independence assumptions. For example, if a state desires to expand access to SNAP, it might simultaneously lengthen certification periods for the elderly while reducing verification requirements for the non-elderly. The former might decrease non-elderly errors and represents the "good" variation, while the latter might increase them, biasing the reduced form towards 0. Additionally, states with high PER may adopt policies aimed at reducing it, introducing bias from reverse causation. In order to address these threats, I control for several state policies.

The Elderly Simplified Application Project (ESAP) is a bundle of policies that states have the option to adopt in order to ease program participation among households with no earned income and where all members are elderly (or, in some states, disabled). These policies include lengthening these households' maximum allowable certification periods from 24 to 36 months, as well as waiving recertification interviews and certain verification paperwork. In regressions focusing on the non-elderly, the certification period change would cause variation in the instrument. The latter policies might reduce administrative workload by themselves, thus impacting non-elderly PER through a mechanism other than the share of cases recertifying. While this could technically be considered an administrative spillover, it would not be an administrative spillover caused by the variable of interest, and thus would bias the reduced form away from zero¹⁷. In order to avoid this exclusion restriction violation, I include a lagged binary control for state ESAP adoption in the regressions for which the non-elderly is the focal group. Controlling for ESAP risks potentially absorbing some of the "good" variation in the first stage, biasing the instrument's coefficient towards 0. However, in practice, inclusion of the ESAP control has the opposite effect, slightly increasing the first stage coefficient but without qualitatively altering it. I do not control for ESAP in regressions focused on the elderly, as it doesn't theoretically violate exclusion for this group.

¹⁷Similar arguments could be made about the SSI Combined Application Project (SSI-CAP). However, I do not control for SSI-CAP as it greatly increases multicollinearity without meaningfully changing the coefficients of interest.

Depending on their certification period, SNAP cases are usually required to perform some form of interim reporting. This can take a variety of forms depending on the state and type of case, such as a requirement to fill out paperwork half way through the certification period, or a requirement to report changes to income or household composition. Reporting regimes are often inextricable from certification periods. For example, a requirement to report income to the stage agency every 6 months is necessarily only applicable to cases with certification periods longer than 6 months. This likely means that state reporting policies are correlated with my instrument. Additionally, many states have adopted a policy of Simplified Reporting, which may reduce payment errors through several mechanisms, including by simplifying administration and reducing the number of things that are counted as errors in the QC (Trippe et al. 2004). Thus, when estimating payment errors for the non-elderly, I control for the lagged fraction of elderly cases which were subject to simplified reporting (and vice versa).

I estimate all regressions with robust standard errors, clustered at the state level.

6 Results

6.1 Effect of Administrative Workload on Combined Error Rates

The results of the state-quarter level regressions are shown in Table 2 and Table 3. The regressions include observations for 51 states across the 4 quarters of FY2022-2024, with state and quarter fixed effects included in all regressions. For both the elderly and non-elderly groups, the first stage relationship between the instrument and the fraction of cases recertifying (columns 1) is significant at the .001% level and is in the expected direction. They indicate that increasing the length of the certification period for the alternate group by 1 standard deviation reduces the fraction of cases recertifying per quarter by 4.1-4.5 percentage points, relative to an average of 16.6-16.9%. For both regressions, the instrument has a Kleibergen-Paap rk Wald F statistic¹⁸ (which I shall refer to as simply the F statistic going forward) above 30.

Unfortunately, the first stage for the elderly focal group (Table 2) is underidentified, with a Kleibergen-Paap rk LM statistic of 3.135 ($p=0.0766$). This is somewhat surprising given that the coefficient on the instrument for the elderly group is similar to that of the case-level regression (Table 4 column 1) and much larger than the coefficient for the non-elderly. The underidentification may be caused by a high degree of collinearity between the instrument and the state fixed effects, with the instrument possessing a VIF of 16.61 in a regression of the elderly instrument and state fixed effects on the endogenous regressor. Other possible culprits include a lack of sufficient variation in the instrument or misspecification, with the first stage relationship potentially being nonlinear (see appendix Figure 1A). Regardless of cause, the underidentification prevents interpretation of the IV state-quarter estimates for the elderly.

The IV results (columns 3 and 5 in Table 3) for the non-elderly group are large and statistically significant ($p < .05$) for both outcomes. The coefficients of interest indicate that, if the fraction of cases recertifying per quarter increased from 0 to 1, then the Case Error Rate (CER) would increase by 29.8 percentage points, and PER would increase by 30.5. On a more grounded level, a one standard deviation increase in the fraction of cases recertifying per quarter (7.2 pp) would cause the the fraction of eligible non-elderly cases with errors increase by 2.1 percentage points relative to the mean of 13%, an increase of about 16%. Similarly, the same increase in recertification causes the fraction of eligible non-elderly benefits that are paid in error would increase by about 2.2 relative to a mean of 5.7%, or about 38%. While these estimates are quite imprecise, they validate the administrative spillover hypothesis. In other words, they show that certifying elderly/disabled SNAP households for longer can reduce the workload faced by state agencies, leading to improved payment accuracy among other groups of recipients.

Interpreting the first stage and IV results together, decreasing the certification period assigned to elderly/disabled households from 24 to 12 months would increase the quarterly share of cases recertifying by

¹⁸I use the Kleibergen-Paap rk Wald F statistic because it is most appropriate for my clustered robust errors.

6.25 percentage points, and this would increase both the PER and CER among eligible non-elderly households by about 1.9 percentage points. This effect is economically significant, given that the average quarterly PER and CER for this group were 5.7% and 13% respectively.

Several of the controls for the non-elderly regressions are worth noting for the sake of context. Longer average certification periods among the non-elderly have the expected relationships, mechanically reducing the fraction of cases recertifying ($p < .001$) in the first stage (column 1), while being imprecisely associated with higher payment errors in the second stage (columns 3 and 5). This latter relationship is line with what we would expect from the verification channel, as well as past research (Kabbani and Wilde 2003, Mills et al. 2004). The coefficients on ESAP are more surprising. State adoption of ESAP should mechanically reduce the frequency of recertification, but the first stage does not find such an association, possibly due to high collinearity with the instrument. More puzzlingly, ESAP is precisely associated with higher payment errors among the non-elderly ($p < .01$) in the IV regressions. This runs contrary to the expectation that some of the ESAP's simplifications would reduce administrative workload and thus payment errors.

Table 2: Effect of Administrative Workload on SNAP Payment Accuracy for the Elderly/Disabled (State-Quarter Level)

	Pct. Recert. in Cert. Q. (1) 1st	Case Error Rate (2) OLS	(3) IV	Payment Error Rate (4) OLS	(5) IV
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period (lag)	-0.0149*** (0.00166)				
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)		0.209** (0.0715)	-0.0448 (0.163)	0.165* (0.0617)	0.0339 (0.174)
Avg. Elderly Cert. Period	-0.000826 (0.000688)	0.000886 (0.000616)	0.000380 (0.000658)	0.000673 (0.000634)	0.000411 (0.000594)
Non-Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	0.0113 (0.0178)	0.00500 (0.0153)	0.00860 (0.0173)	0.00121 (0.0109)	0.00308 (0.0111)
Unemployment rate (lag)	0.201 (0.501)	0.00442 (0.389)	-0.0242 (0.425)	0.240 (0.366)	0.225 (0.368)
Constant	0.315*** (0.0349)	0.0230 (0.0347)		0.00894 (0.0275)	
State and Quarter FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	601	601	601	601	601
KP F-stat	80.65				

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 3: Effect of Administrative Workload on SNAP Payment Accuracy for the Non-Elderly (State-Quarter Level)

	Pct. Recert. in Cert. Q. (1) 1st	Case Error Rate (2) OLS	(3) IV	Payment Error Rate (4) OLS	(5) IV
Avg. Elderly Cert. Period (lag)	-0.00521*** (0.000948)				
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)		0.0985 (0.0634)	0.298* (0.148)	0.0860** (0.0289)	0.305* (0.135)
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period	-0.00843*** (0.000989)	0.000243 (0.00146)	0.00232 (0.00219)	0.00148* (0.000645)	0.00377* (0.00153)
Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	-0.00643 (0.0124)	0.00239 (0.00783)	0.00422 (0.00861)	-0.00321 (0.00523)	-0.00119 (0.00563)
ESAP (lag)	0.00968 (0.0109)	0.0165* (0.00754)	0.0226** (0.00838)	0.0111** (0.00407)	0.0179** (0.00625)
Unemployment rate (lag)	0.294 (0.487)	-0.309 (0.375)	-0.375 (0.333)	-0.206 (0.305)	-0.279 (0.242)
Constant	0.314*** (0.0396)	0.0946** (0.0343)		0.0240 (0.0233)	
State and Quarter FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	601	601	601	601	601
KP F-stat	30.26				

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

The results for the case-level regressions are shown in Table 4 and Table 5. Not shown are the controls for whether households are single parent households, have children, have an elderly/disabled person, or have a female head. All models are identified, though most estimates are fairly imprecise, in spite of the much larger sample sizes. A large number of SNAP cases were certified during a quarter not observed in the QC data (FY 2020-2021), and thus were missing observations for all lagged variables, including the instrument and endogenous regressor of interest. Such cases were dropped from estimation, causing the number of observations in the case-level regressions to be lower than the totals shown in Table 1. Just as with the state-quarter level regressions, the case level first stage relationships between the instrument and the fraction of cases recertifying (columns 1) is significant at the .001% level and negative, with F statistics over 30 for both groups. They indicate that increasing the elderly and non-elderly certification periods by 1 month decreases the fraction of cases recertifying each quarter by .48 percentage points and 1.41 percentage points respectively, relative to a mean of about 17%.

None of the case level IV results were statistically significant, though the coefficients of interest for the non-elderly households were large. Taken at face value, the estimate in Table 5 column 3 would indicate that increasing the fraction of cases recertifying by 1 standard deviation is associated with the probability of an error increasing by 1.4 percentage points, or about 11% relative to the mean probability of 12.9%. The coefficient in column 5 suggests that this would also increase the average payment error amount per case by \$4.24, relative to a mean of \$27.42. The elderly IV results were smaller but ran in the same direction. However, none of these relationships were statistically significant.

Unlike in the state-quarter regressions, ESAP implementation is not strongly associated with any IV outcomes. Meanwhile, the probability and amount of payment errors are strongly and positively associated with household size and whether a household has earned income.

Multicollinearity is a prominent feature of my results. While, no regression had a mean VIF above 10, key variables were typically collinear. The instrument had VIF's of 19.2 and 36.4 in the state quarter level regressions for the elderly and non-elderly, respectively. The case level regressions, with their larger and more varied samples, were slightly better. The case level instrument for the non-elderly had a VIF of 22, and the instrument in the elderly regressions had a much smaller VIF of 9. The instruments' collinearity seems to be primarily attributable to the state fixed effects, dropping by more than half when these effects are excluded from estimation. For the non-elderly regressions, the ESAP control had a VIF above 10 for both datasets. This control seems to explain the remainder of the instruments' VIF. Finally, the control for a groups own certification period (Avg. Elderly Cert. Period and Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period) had a VIF over 10 in all regressions. It is not clear what these variables are collinear with but removing them has minimal impact on the instrument's VIF, and vice-versa.

6.2 Effect by Type of Error

The error rates in the previous regressions are the sum of underpayments and overpayments to eligible households. These two types of errors might experience different trends or affects from administrative spillover. Thus, I rerun my model for each type of error, second stage results for which are shown in Table 6 and Table 7¹⁹. For each group and dataset, the coefficients predicting overpayments and underpayments sum to the coefficients in the models predicting combined payment errors among the eligible (Tables 2-5). While this indicates that these regressions properly decompose the overall relationships by type of error, it also means that the effect sizes are much smaller. This, combined with a lack of precision, means that none of the IV estimates of administrative workload on type of error are statistically significant. Given that this is a mechanical artifact of splitting things up by type, it seems likely that the relationships estimated in these tables are similarly valid as the results in the previous tables (both good and bad). Among the non-elderly, the administrative workload during the quarter of certification has a similar effect on whether a case will have an overpayment or an underpayment. However, in terms of the fraction of benefits paid in error, this seems to increase overpayments by about three times as much as it does underpayments.

¹⁹First stage estimates are not shown because these specifications use the same first stage as the previous regressions.

Table 4: Effect of Administrative Workload on SNAP Payment Accuracy for the Elderly/Disabled (Case Level)

	Pct. Recert. in Cert. Q. (1) 1st	Prob. of Payment Error (2) OLS	(3) IV	Amount of Payment Error (4) OLS	(5) IV
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period (lag)	-0.0141*** (0.00134)				
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)		0.0241 (0.0362)	0.107 (0.101)	-0.456 (5.212)	18.44 (16.16)
Avg. Elderly Cert. Period	-0.00152** (0.000543)	0.000177 (0.000606)	0.000396 (0.000707)	0.0718 (0.0910)	0.121 (0.104)
Non-Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	0.00200 (0.00615)	-0.00971 (0.00503)	-0.00963* (0.00489)	-1.245 (0.743)	-1.227 (0.737)
Unemployment Rate (lag)	-0.112 (0.330)	0.152 (0.259)	0.183 (0.255)	55.48 (44.59)	62.42 (43.60)
HH Size	0.000590 (0.000789)	0.0517*** (0.00799)	0.0516*** (0.00792)	12.58*** (1.664)	12.57*** (1.649)
Working Poor	-0.000544 (0.00106)	0.103*** (0.0125)	0.103*** (0.0124)	21.57*** (2.746)	21.58*** (2.720)
Cert. During Pandemic	0.0244** (0.00719)	-0.00503 (0.00460)	-0.00655 (0.00493)	-0.851 (0.618)	-1.197 (0.697)
Constant	0.348*** (0.0236)	0.0220 (0.0157)		-4.926 (2.722)	
State and Quarter FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	45383	45383	45383	45383	45383
KP F-stat	110.2				

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 5: Effect of Administrative Workload on SNAP Payment Accuracy for the Non-Elderly (Case Level)

	Pct. Recert. in Cert. Q. (1) 1st	Prob. of Payment Error (2) OLS	(3) IV	Amount of Payment Error (4) OLS	(5) IV
Avg. Elderly Cert. Period (lag)	-0.00483*** (0.000793)				
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)		0.00191 (0.0353)	0.177 (0.199)	8.046 (9.003)	52.33 (51.35)
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period	-0.00933*** (0.000932)	-0.000810 (0.00178)	0.00121 (0.00252)	0.167 (0.406)	0.678 (0.613)
ESAP (lag)	0.00466 (0.0108)	-0.0171* (0.00652)	-0.0123 (0.00802)	-2.838 (1.865)	-1.625 (2.552)
HH Size	-0.00000799 (0.000114)	0.0183*** (0.00155)	0.0183*** (0.00154)	6.070*** (0.507)	6.073*** (0.503)
Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	-0.00418 (0.00730)	-0.00563 (0.00558)	-0.00445 (0.00572)	-1.485 (1.422)	-1.185 (1.495)
Unemployment Rate (lag)	-0.453 (0.293)	-0.0637 (0.251)	0.0247 (0.257)	33.67 (77.35)	56.02 (72.13)
Working Poor	0.000000535 (0.000322)	0.131*** (0.00846)	0.131*** (0.00840)	29.66*** (2.585)	29.66*** (2.564)
Cert. During Pandemic	0.0174 (0.00943)	0.0169** (0.00574)	0.0142* (0.00604)	3.999* (1.501)	3.294* (1.382)
Constant	0.384*** (0.0223)	-0.00512 (0.0275)		-13.18 (6.634)	
State and Quarter FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	69732	69732	69732	69732	69732
KP F-stat	37.05				

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 6: Second Stage Estimates by Type of Error (State-Quarter Level)

	Elderly				Non-Elderly			
	Case Error Rate		Payment Error Rate		Case Error Rate		Payment Error Rate	
	(1) Under	(2) Over	(3) Under	(4) Over	(5) Under	(6) Over	(7) Under	(8) Over
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)	-0.104 (0.170)	0.0592 (0.113)	-0.122 (0.178)	0.156 (0.0984)	0.157 (0.0991)	0.141 (0.199)	0.0728 (0.0380)	0.233 (0.162)
Avg. Cert. Period (Own Group)	0.000316 (0.000495)	0.0000646 (0.000680)	-0.0000446 (0.000405)	0.000456 (0.000645)	0.00167 (0.00146)	0.000649 (0.00228)	0.000539 (0.000479)	0.00323* (0.00160)
Other Group Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	0.0169 (0.0115)	-0.00833 (0.0139)	0.0141 (0.00954)	-0.0111 (0.0107)	0.0120** (0.00439)	-0.00781 (0.00951)	0.00580*** (0.00174)	-0.00699 (0.00568)
ESAP (lag)					0.00433 (0.00614)	0.0183* (0.00897)	0.000596 (0.00252)	0.0173* (0.00711)
Unemployment rate (lag)	0.0726 (0.330)	-0.0968 (0.248)	0.0487 (0.296)	0.177 (0.245)	-0.141 (0.146)	-0.234 (0.334)	-0.0545 (0.0788)	-0.224 (0.240)
State and Quarter FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	601	601	601	601	601	601	601	601

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 7: Second Stage Estimates by Type of Error (Case Level)

	Elderly				Non-Elderly			
	Prob. of Error		Amount of Error		Prob. of Error		Amount of Error	
	(1) Under	(2) Over	(3) Under	(4) Over	(5) Under	(6) Over	(7) Under	(8) Over
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)	0.0490 (0.0451)	0.0584 (0.0800)	7.260 (6.315)	11.18 (14.97)	0.0855 (0.103)	0.0913 (0.141)	12.67 (21.37)	39.66 (39.15)
Avg. Cert. Period (Own Group)	0.000193 (0.000338)	0.000203 (0.000601)	0.0164 (0.0427)	0.105 (0.0996)	0.00139 (0.00147)	-0.000178 (0.00174)	-0.00231 (0.276)	0.680 (0.452)
Other Group Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	-0.00145 (0.00292)	-0.00819 (0.00487)	-0.111 (0.325)	-1.116 (0.741)	0.00460 (0.00331)	-0.00905 (0.00493)	1.172 (0.747)	-2.357 (1.276)
ESAP (lag)					-0.00568 (0.00519)	-0.00658 (0.00702)	-0.954 (1.124)	-0.671 (2.578)
Unemployment Rate (lag)	-0.110 (0.152)	0.293 (0.222)	-8.504 (19.75)	70.92 (39.54)	0.0140 (0.155)	0.0107 (0.248)	15.89 (30.26)	40.13 (68.77)
HH Size	0.00553 (0.00305)	0.0461*** (0.00718)	1.775** (0.574)	10.79*** (1.507)	0.00984*** (0.00102)	0.00847*** (0.00126)	2.624*** (0.288)	3.448*** (0.418)
Working Poor	-0.00404 (0.00320)	0.107*** (0.0117)	-0.642 (0.432)	22.22*** (2.637)	0.0144*** (0.00199)	0.117*** (0.00866)	0.783* (0.355)	28.88*** (2.659)
Cert. During Pandemic	-0.00297 (0.00216)	-0.00358 (0.00420)	-0.430 (0.270)	-0.767 (0.591)	0.00159 (0.00374)	0.0126** (0.00442)	-0.354 (0.627)	3.648** (1.309)
State and Quarter FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	45383	45383	45383	45383	69732	69732	69732	69732

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

7 Discussion and Robustness Checks

My state-quarter level regressions seem to indicate that administrative workload causes higher payment errors among SNAP households where not all members are elderly or disabled. This would provide evidence that requiring more frequent recertification can act to increase a state’s errors to the extent that this would increase workload. However, even if we were to suppose that this result is correct, there are several important nuances to its interpretation. As I discussed in my Data Section, administrative spillovers are only one way in which changing a state’s certification period might affect their PER. The net treatment effect of shortening certification periods on PER might still be negative if the other mechanisms dominate. Additionally, my results only estimate the effect of recertification on payment errors among eligible cases, as the public QC data does not allow me to directly observe SNAP payments to ineligible cases. This limits how much they can tell us about the total amount of dollars paid in error, as eligible cases only account for about 25% of total PER.

If workload increases these errors then it seems plausible that ineligible errors would be similarly affected. If an increased workload would cause a caseworker to mistakenly allot too many benefits to eligible household more often, then it seems reasonable to expect that they might also more often award benefits to ineligible households. In particular, my estimates for CER are likely informative about the overall occurrence of payment errors, as roughly 71% of cases with errors in FY2023 were eligible²⁰. For this reason, I focus my discussion and robustness checks on CER and the case level probability of errors. Future research will require access to more detailed QC data in order to determining the impact of administrative workload on ineligible payment errors.

I do not find evidence that administrative workload increases payment errors among the roughly 40% of SNAP households where all members are either elderly or disabled. The state-quarter estimate for the elderly was underidentified, and even in the case level data the IV estimate was much smaller in magnitude than it was for the non-elderly (though neither was statistically significant). There are several possible explanations for this discrepancy. It is plausible that the treatment effect is genuinely heterogeneous, and that administrative workload matters for the non-elderly but not for the elderly. Compared to their non-elderly counterparts, elderly SNAP cases may be simpler to administer, with less that can go wrong during certification. As shown in Table 1, eligible non-elderly households are more likely to have a payment error, possibly because they are more likely to have earned income.

Lack of identifying variation in the instrument might also explain the different results between groups, as the average certification period varied a lot more for the elderly than it did for the non-elderly. Among elderly cases in my regression sample, the average non-elderly certification period in their month of certification had a standard deviation of only 3.1 months, while for the non-elderly cases the analogous figured is 7.9 months. This lack of variation may be why the elderly state-quarter regression was underidentified. Thus it’s possible that the elderly may be affected by administrative spillovers, but no such spillovers happened to occur during the period of analysis.

The fact that the non-elderly state-quarter level results are not reflected in the case level data may indicate that the results are not internally valid, and demands explanation. If administrative workload during the quarter of certification does indeed increase the overall rate of errors, we would expect to see that at the level of the household. The puzzling lack of precision in the case level estimates could be partially responsible. While the case level IV coefficient of interest is much smaller, it also has a much larger standard error than the state-quarter non-elderly estimate, in spite of having a sample size several orders of magnitude larger. I do not have a confident explanation for this, though it could be partially attributable to multicollinearity or the fact that Table 5 column 3 is a linear probability model. The case level controls in this model, such as working status or household size, also do not account for its divergence from the state-quarter level results. The inclusion of these controls either increases the magnitude and precision of the IV coefficient of interest, or has a negligible effect.

²⁰This is based on the number of errors in my dataset and the number of ineligible cases recorded in the QC documentation.

It's possible that the difference is an artifact of aggregation. As mentioned previously, a large number of cases are dropped from the case level regressions because they certified during the pandemic, and thus I was unable to observe the instrument and endogenous regressor for these cases. However, their payment errors were still observable and included when calculating the state-quarter level outcomes. This may have biased state-quarter level estimates upwards, as such cases were 2pp more likely to have an error ($p < .01$)²¹.

In order to examine this possibility, I perform a robustness check in column 8 of Table 8. Here, I regress my primary state-quarter specification against an alternate form of my CER measure, calculated without cases whose certification period was not observable. The IV coefficient of interest shrinks from .298 to .23, losing statistical significance.

As I described in my results section, my instrument is collinear in most specification, which undermines confidence in my results likely contributes to my estimates' imprecision. There is limited variation in the certification periods within states over time, leading the instrument to be highly collinear with state fixed effects. To investigate the effect of this, I perform a robustness check in columns 3 and 4 Table 8 and Table 9 where I estimate my primary specifications for the occurrence of errors (CER and the probability of having an error) without state fixed effects. While the non-elderly results become less precise, and the case level identification suffers, the magnitudes of the effects change remarkably little. This indicates that my results for this group are not driven by the fixed effects. The regressions for the elderly group remain statistically insignificant, but become better identified and negative. Thus the fixed effects may play more of a role for this group, which is unsurprising as there's relatively less variation in its instrument.

The control for each group's own certification period, intended as a control for policies affecting the certification periods of both groups, is collinear in all primary specifications, though not collinear with the instrument. To examine the role of this control in shaping outcomes, I estimate my primary results for CER and the probability of error using an alternative version of this control. Instead of controlling for average assigned certification period, the regressions shown in columns 1 and 2 of Table 8 and Table 9 use a measure of average time elapsed since certification among a group, which has a VIF is below 10 in all specifications. While the magnitudes of the effects of interest change relatively little, all but the case level elderly specification become underidentified. Experimentation finds that this is almost entirely attributable to removal of the original own-certification control, rather than the addition of the alternate one. These results indicate that properly accounting for the certification periods of both groups is essential to identifying the first stage relationships.

The Elderly Simplified Application Project is a key variable for the regressions where the non-elderly are the focal group. It is a necessary control for a potential exclusion restriction violation (see my Methods section). However, the policy is also one of the primary causes of variation in my instrument. Thus my ESAP control is highly collinear with my instrument and likely absorbs some of the desirable identifying variation. To examine how ESAP affects my results, I perform a number of robustness checks shown in Table 10 and Table 11.

In each table, Column 1 shows my primary specifications for sake of comparison, while Column 2 shows the same regression without the binary ESAP control. Without the control, the state-quarter level coefficient of interest collapses to 0, while the case level effect almost doubles, attaining statistical significance ($p < .05$). The VIF falls from 36.4 to 19.58 for my state-quarter instrument, while the case level instrument's VIF falls from 21.97 to 13.87. Though the state-quarter level F-statistic falls below 30, the 1st stage coefficients (not shown) minimally affected. Thus, the changes to the coefficients of interest are primarily due to changes to the reduced form relationship between the average elderly certification period and the rate at which payment errors occur. Inclusion of the ESAP control was originally motivated by a concern that the reduced form effect would otherwise be biased upwards, and though the change in the case level effect is directionally consistent with this, the state-quarter level change is not. It is not clear why my datasets respond so differently to the ESAP control, but it potentially threatens the interpretation of my results.

²¹Draft Notes: This is a potentially serious flaw of aggregation and I intend to redo my primary SQ regressions. However I had already written my results section by the time I figured this out and I didn't have enough time to redo things.

To further investigate the impact of ESAP, I estimate my results in Column 3 of Table 10 and Table 11 with a linear timetrend representing the number of quarters since a state has adopted ESAP. Compared to the primary specifications, the state-quarter effect decreases by about a third, losing significance, while the case level effect becomes much larger and more precise ($p < .01$). While the instruments' VIF scores improve relative to baseline for both datasets, ESAP timetrend has a VIF of over 140 due to severe collinearity with the state fixed effects. This multicollinearity makes it difficult to interpret the changes to the effects of interest.

The ESAP policy likely violates the exclusion restriction by driving recertification rates while causing administrative workload to fall independently of the share of cases recertifying. However, this variation might be desirable for identification if we are more broadly interested in the effects of administrative workload. Thus I estimate specifications that include the binary indicator of ESAP as an additional instrument, and as the only instrument, in columns 4 and 5, respectively, of Table 10 and Table 11. The regressions with ESAP as an additional instrument show a similar pattern to the previous ESAP robustness checks, with the case level coefficient growing while the state-quarter effect shrinks. The coefficients of interest where ESAP is the only instrument are both very large but in opposite directions. Perhaps more importantly, the identification of these results is not compelling, with low F-statistics for all regressions, while the state-quarter level regression in Column 4 is overidentified. Given the weak identification, these regressions likely tell us very little about administrative workload's effects on payment errors²².

Taken together, the regressions in Table 10 and Table 11 indicate that my results are highly sensitive to whether and how I account for ESAP. Future research on SNAP certification periods will need to take this into consideration.

Finally, I am concerned that the first stages may be misspecified. As I show in Figure A1, the unconditional first stage relationships appear to be nonlinear. This is at least partially mechanical, ie: arithmetically, increasing elderly certification periods from 24 to 36 months will have less of an effect on the share of cases recertifying than increasing it from 12 to 24 months, all else equal. While this would not bias my IV estimates, it may reduce their precision and means that the LATE recovered by my models will more heavily weight some regions of variation than others, complicating interpretation. To account for this, I construct linearized versions of my instruments by taking the reciprocal $\frac{3}{z}$ and rerunning my primary specifications with this new instrument in columns 5 and 6 of Table 8 and Table 9. If the original instrument z represents the average certification period for the alternate group, then this new instrument represents the average fraction of cases in the alternate group who will recertify per quarter. In the state-quarter dataset, the linearization causes the elderly regression to become identified, though its effect changes little, while the non-elderly IV result grows in magnitude and significance but becomes underidentified. Interestingly, the magnitude and F-statistic approximately double for the case level non-elderly IV result. However, a lack of precision means that it is still statistically insignificant.

8 Work in Progress

To my committee,

This paper is a draft and there are a lot of improvements or additions that I hope to make, either during revision, or in future papers:

- I intend to perform a fiscal analysis where I calculate how much money might actually be affected by the effects that I estimate, both in terms of payment error dollars but also in terms of how much states would be on the hook for. A 1% reduction in the fraction of cases recertifying per quarter might reduce non-elderly PER by x amount, leading to y amount of dollars saved.

²²Draft Notes: I do not think that ESAP makes for a compelling instrument. I primarily included these robustness checks because several of you asked me to look into it.

- I definitely want to put more time into thinking through more threats to identification and possible policy endogeneity.
- Put more focus on the case level data, and less on the state-quarter data. The focus on the state-quarter data was largely a vestigial element, relevant to analyses that I didn't end up doing.
- In the case level data I should take advantage of the large sample size to control for more things: TANF participation, SSI, income, etc.
- I want to find ways to make my case level regressions more precise. Maybe I'll look into whether bootstrapping SE's for my case level data will improve the precision of the estimates.
- I very much plan to do a simulated eligibility type instrument. I take state certification period rules and apply them to a fixed set of SNAP cases, then used this simulated certification periods as instruments for the actual certification periods. This would allow me to recover the overall treatment effect of certification period length, which would be a lot more useful to policymakers than just estimating the effect of one mechanism. Might need to be a separate paper, but I got half way through data collection for this before I decided I should spend my time polishing the models that I already had.
- I want to dig into the QC data more and look at the timing of when errors occurred and what the errors were (ie income, deductions, household composition, etc.). There's also a lot of descriptive analysis that I want to do which would likely be of interest to state agencies.
- I want to look at the results in the pre-pandemic period.
- I want to put more thought into how best to implement my policy controls, particularly ESAP and how to properly account for simplified reporting (there's probably some interactions).
- I want to find alternative measures of administrative workload, or a way to control for the level of administrative resources in a state. In particular, I want to use publicly available data on state government employees to measure staffing and turnover at state SNAP agencies.
- I want to tighten up the labels, tables, and overall presentation of information. The construction of my instruments and endogenous regressors are pretty complicated, and I want to put some time into finding ways to explain them more clearly. This would be useful in my eventual elevator pitch.
- I might want to go into slightly more detail for the institutional background. I feel like some of the background information is scattered throughout the paper and I want to organize it better.
- I also want to engage more with the public administration literature. I've only really looked at papers studying payment accuracy in SNAP, but there must be research into payment accuracy and administrative workload for other programs in the world.

9 Conclusion

I find evidence that administrative workload can increase payment errors among certain types of eligible SNAP cases. This means that shorter certification periods can increase Payment Error Rates to the extent that they increase the workload faced by state agencies. However, these results are not robust, with a number of empirical challenges that must be resolved before they can be taken strong evidence of a relationship. My results do suggest that future researchers should question the centrality of the accuracy-access tradeoff, which has remained a focal-point of the literature, despite the relative lack of evidence for its practical relevance to SNAP certification periods and PER.

These findings are relevant to states searching for strategies to reduce their PER in order to avoid the hefty financial penalties levied by the One Big Beautiful Bill Act. Adopting shorter certification periods in order to improve verification of participant information may be counterproductive if the increased workload from processing these recertifications leads administrators to make more mistakes. Further research is

urgently needed in order to determine the net effect that shorter certification periods have on PER. While my results do not estimate this net effect, they suggest that states should be careful to consider how policy changes may affect their staff and their overall administrative capacity.

10 Works Cited

American Public Human Services Association. 2023. "Payment Error Rates: Understanding What They Are and How to Support SNAP Agencies in Reducing Them." Washington, DC: APHSA. <https://aphsa.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/07/96c3eef9-9ae5-43f8-a2c1-6003e0851226.pdf>.

Benvie, Catherine, Michael Ribar, John Knaus, Victoria Perez-Zetune, Katie Powell, Megan Worden, Polina Zvavitch, Olivia Iles, Patricia McGinn, and Elizabeth Weber. 2023. Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program State Options Report, 15th ed. Prepared by Westat for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, Program Development Division, October 2023.

Bergh, Katie, and Dottie Rosenbaum. 2026. "Congressional Delay of SNAP Cost Shift Urgently Needed to Protect Food Assistance for Low-Income Families." Washington, DC: Center on Budget and Policy Priorities, January 8, 2026. <https://www.cbpp.org/research/food-assistance/congressional-delay-of-snap-cost-shift-urgently-needed-to-protect-food>.

Currie, Janet, and Jeffrey Grogger. 2001. "Explaining Recent Declines in Food Stamp Program Participation." Brookings-Wharton Papers on Urban Affairs: 203–44.

Fannin, W. Clay. 2025. "Can Reducing Administrative Burdens Increase Benefit Amounts? Evidence from SNAP Simplified Reporting." *Applied Economic Perspectives and Policy* 47 (3): 965–982. <https://doi.org/10.1002/aep.13508>.

Feeding America. 2026. "H.R. 1 'One Big Beautiful Bill Act' FAQ." Last updated June 24, 2026. Chicago: Feeding America. <https://www.feedingamerica.org>.

Finkelstein, Amy, and Matthew J. Notowidigdo. 2019. "Take-Up and Targeting: Experimental Evidence from SNAP." *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 134 (3): 1505–1556.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2018. Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program State Options Report, 14th ed. Options as of October 1, 2017. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Agriculture, Program Development Division, May 31, 2018.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2021. "Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program: Non-Discretionary Quality Control Provisions of the Agricultural Improvement Act of 2018." Interim Final Rule. 86 Fed. Reg. 44575 (August 13, 2021). <https://www.fns.usda.gov/snap/fr-081321>.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2022. SNAP Quality Control Review Handbook. FNS Handbook 310. Alexandria, VA: U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, October 2021, through QC Policy Memo 22-02.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2023. "Provisions to Improve the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program's Quality Control System." Notice of Proposed Rulemaking. 88 Fed. Reg. 64756 (September 19, 2023). FNS-2020-0016. <https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2023/09/19/2023-20023/provisions-to-improve-the-supplemental-nutrition-assistance-programs-quality-control-system>.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2025. Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) Quality Control Annual Report Fiscal Year 2023. Washington, DC: United States Department of Agriculture. <https://fns->

prod.azureedge.us/sites/default/files/resource-files/snap-qc-annualreportfy23.pdf.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2026. "SNAP Quality Control—Payment Error Rates." Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Agriculture. Accessed August 2, 2026. <https://www.fns.usda.gov/snap/qc/per>.

Food and Nutrition Administration. 2026. "Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program: Payment Error Rates, Fiscal Year 2025." Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Agriculture. June 24, 2026.

Food and Nutrition Service. 2026. "Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program Participation and Costs." Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Agriculture. Data as of July 10, 2026. <https://www.fns.usda.gov/pd/supplemental-nutrition-assistance-program-snap>.

Food Research and Action Center. 2025. "Shifting the Burden: How the Recently Passed Budget Reconciliation Package Reshapes SNAP and Strains State Budgets." Washington, DC: FRAC, July 30, 2025. <https://frac.org/blog/shifting-the-burden-how-the-recently-passed-budget-reconciliation-package-reshapes-snap-and-strains-state-budgets>.

Fox, Ashley, Wei Feng, and Mackenzie Reynolds. 2023. "The Effect of Administrative Burden on State Safety-Net Participation: Evidence from Food Assistance, Cash Assistance, and Medicaid." *Public Administration Review* 83 (2): 367–384. <https://doi.org/10.1111/puar.13497>.

Geller, David, Julia Isaacs, Breno Braga, and Brice Zic. 2019. Exploring the Causes of State Variation in SNAP Administrative Costs. Washington, DC: Manhattan Strategy Group and Urban Institute, prepared for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, February 2019.

Giannella, Eric, Tatiana Homonoff, Gabriel Rino, and Jason Somerville. 2024. "Administrative Burden and Procedural Denials: Experimental Evidence from SNAP." *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy* 16 (4): 316–340.

Gray, Colin. 2019. "Leaving Benefits on the Table: Evidence from SNAP." *Journal of Public Economics* 179: 104054.

Hanratty, Maria J. 2006. "Has the Food Stamp Program Become More Accessible? Impacts of Recent Changes in Reporting Requirements and Asset Eligibility Limits." *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management* 25 (3): 603–621. <https://doi.org/10.1002/pam.20193>.

Hastings, Justine, and Jesse M. Shapiro. 2018. "How Are SNAP Benefits Spent? Evidence from a Retail Panel." *American Economic Review* 108 (12): 3493–3540.

Herd, Pamela, and Donald P. Moynihan. 2019. *Administrative Burden: Policymaking by Other Means*. Chicago: Russell Sage Foundation. <https://doi.org/10.7758/9781610448789>.

Homonoff, Tatiana, and Jason Somerville. 2021. "Program Recertification Costs: Evidence from SNAP." *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy* 13 (4): 271–98.

Illinois Department of Human Services. 2025. "Impact of Federal SNAP Cuts on Illinois Families and Illinois' Response." PowerPoint presentation, October 15, 2025.

Johnson, Mike. 2025. "Transcript: House Speaker Mike Johnson on 'Face the Nation with Margaret Brennan.'" Interview by Margaret Brennan. *Face the Nation*. CBS News, May 25, 2025. <https://www.cbsnews.com/news/mike-johnson-house-speaker-face-the-nation-transcript-05-25-2025/>.

Kabbani, Nader S., and Parke E. Wilde. 2003. "Short Recertification Periods in the U.S. Food Stamp Program." *Journal of Human Resources* 38: 1112–38.

Kornfeld, Robert. 2002. Explaining Recent Trends in Food Stamp Program Caseloads. E-FAN-02-008. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Agriculture, Economic Research Service.

Leftin, Joshua, Mia Monkovic, Francisco Yang, Nima Rahimi, Andrew Wen, and Alma Vigil. 2024. Technical Documentation for the Fiscal Year 2022 Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program Quality Control Database and the QC Minimodel. Final Report. Washington, DC: Mathematica, prepared for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, March 2024. Contract No. 12-3198-23-F-0016.

Leftin, Joshua, Mia Monkovic, Francisco Yang, John Carlo Maula, and Sam Bonelli. 2025. Technical Documentation for the Fiscal Year 2023 Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program Quality Control Database and the QC Minimodel. Final Report. Washington, DC: Mathematica, prepared for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, April 2025. Contract No. 12-3198-23-F-0047.

Leftin, Joshua, Mia Monkovic, Francisco Yang, Sam Bonelli, and John Carlo Maula. 2026. Technical Documentation for the Fiscal Year 2024 Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program Quality Control Database and the QC Minimodel. Final Report. Washington, DC: Mathematica, prepared for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, May 2026. Contract No. 12-3198-24-Q-0029.

Logan, Christopher, Ryan Kling, and William Rhodes. 2008. Food Stamp Program Certification Costs and Errors, 1989–2005. Final Report. Contractor and Cooperator Report No. 45. Washington, DC: Abt Associates Inc., prepared for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Economic Research Service, June 2008. Contract No. 59-5000-6-0078.

McConnell, Casey, Lindsey Morgan, Catherine Benvie, Michael Ribar, Olivia Iles, John Knaus, Victoria Perez-Zetune, Katie Powell, Polina Zvavitch, and Elizabeth Weber. 2024. Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program State Options Report, 16th ed. Prepared by Westat for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, Program Development Division, June 2024.

McConnell, Casey, Lindsey Morgan, Michael Ribar, Catherine Benvie, Olivia Iles, John Knaus, Katie Powell, Megan Worden, Greeshma James, and Elizabeth Weber. 2025. Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program State Options Report, 17th ed. Prepared by Westat for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service, Program Development Division, December 2025.

Mills, Gregory, Tracy Vericker, Heather Koball, Kye Lippold, Laura Wheaton, and Sam Elkin. 2014. Understanding the Rates, Causes, and Costs of Churning in the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program. Alexandria, VA: Office of Policy Support, Food and Nutrition Service, United States Department of Agriculture.

Mills, Gregory, Diana Laliberty, and Carole Rodger. 2004. Food Stamp Certification Periods and Payment Accuracy: State Experience During 1997–2001. E-FAN-04-012. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Agriculture, Economic Research Service.

Ratcliffe, Caroline, Signe-Mary McKernan, and Kenneth Finegold. 2008. "Effects of Food Stamp and TANF Policies on Food Stamp Receipt." *Social Service Review* 82 (2): 291–334. <https://doi.org/10.1086/589707>.

Ribar, David C., Marilyn Edelhoach, and Qiduan Liu. 2008. "Watching the Clocks: The Role of Food Stamp Recertification and TANF Time Limits in Caseload Dynamics." *Journal of Human Resources* 43 (1): 208–39.

Rosenbaum, Dorothy, and Katie Bergh. 2023. "SNAP Includes an Extensive Payment Accuracy System." Washington, DC: Center on Budget and Policy Priorities. <https://www.cbpp.org/sites/default/files/6-28-23fa.pdf>.

Trippe, Carole, Liz Schott, Nancy Wemmerus, and Andrew Burwick. 2004. Simplified Reporting and Transitional Benefits in the Food Stamp Program—Case Studies of State Implementation. Final Report. E-FAN-04-003. Washington, DC: Mathematica Policy Research, Inc., prepared for U.S. Department of Agriculture, Economic Research Service, May 2004.

U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Administration. 2025. "SNAP Quality Control." Accessed August 1, 2026. <https://www.fna.usda.gov/snap/qc>.

U.S. Department of Agriculture, Office of Inspector General. 2015. FNS Quality Control Process for SNAP Error Rate. Audit Report No. 27601-0002-41. Washington, DC: USDA OIG, September 23, 2015.

Ward, Ronald. 2025. "Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program Provisions of the One Big Beautiful Bill Act of 2025 — Information Memorandum." Memorandum to All SNAP State Agencies, All Regions. Alexandria, VA: Food and Nutrition Service, U.S. Department of Agriculture, September 4, 2025. <https://www.fns.usda.gov/obbb/snap>.

7 C.F.R. § 275.23(b) (2024).

11 Appendix A: Robustness Checks

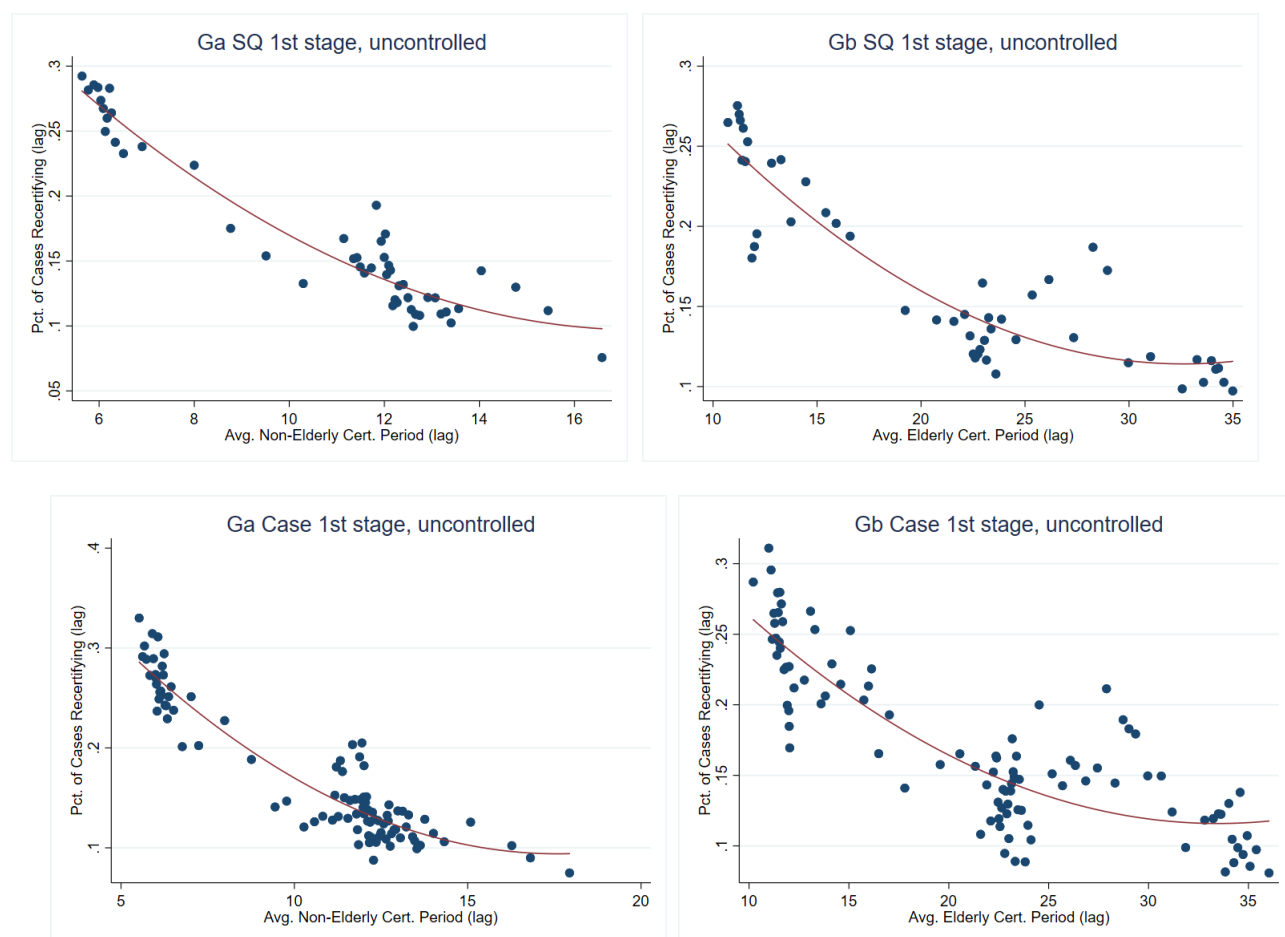


Figure A1: Unconditional 1st Stage Relationships for Each Group and Dataset

Table 8: Alternative Second Stage Estimates for the Case Error Rate by Focal Group (State-Quarter Level)

	Alt-Cert. Control (1) Elderly	(2) Non-elderly	No State FE (3) Elderly	(4) Non-elderly	Linearized Instrument (5) Elderly	(6) Non-elderly	Alt. Outcome (7) Elderly	(8) Non-elderly
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)	-0.0568 (0.160)	0.222* (0.0953)	-0.114 (0.107)	0.279 (0.232)	-0.0505 (0.150)	0.428** (0.161)	0.0417 (0.129)	0.230 (0.159)
Avg. Elderly Cert. Period			-0.000372 (0.000810)		0.000369 (0.000682)		0.000683 (0.000804)	
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period				0.00717 (0.00454)		0.00369 (0.00258)		0.00145 (0.00236)
Non-Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	0.00862 (0.0173)		-0.0127 (0.0190)		0.00869 (0.0171)		0.00322 (0.0169)	
Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)		0.00562 (0.00833)		-0.0115 (0.0113)		0.00543 (0.00938)		0.00446 (0.00807)
ESAP (lag)		0.0202** (0.00754)		0.0303* (0.0119)		0.0267** (0.00877)		0.0198* (0.00777)
Unemployment rate (lag)	-0.0252 (0.470)	-0.439 (0.327)	0.900* (0.457)	0.805 (0.522)	-0.0248 (0.426)	-0.419 (0.325)	-0.527 (0.461)	-0.679 (0.429)
Avg. Mo. Since Cert. GA	0.000255 (0.000905)							
Avg. Mo. Since Cert. GB		0.00226 (0.00131)						
Constant			0.0756 (0.0492)	-0.0678 (0.0906)				
Observations	601	601	601	601	601	601	601	601
KP rk Wald F-stat (excluded instrument)	85.98	28.92	112.8	31.64	199.2	40.78	80.65	30.26
Underidentification Test p-value	0.0705	0.0909	0.0000142	0.0000548	0.0305	0.0678	0.0766	0.0469

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 9: Alternative Second Stage Estimates for the Probability of Payment Error by Focal Group (Case Level)

	Alt-cert Control		No State FE		Linearized Instrument	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Elderly	Non-elderly	Elderly	Non-elderly	Elderly	Non-elderly
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)	0.0994 (0.0948)	0.151 (0.157)	-0.104 (0.103)	0.174 (0.263)	0.0751 (0.0917)	0.374 (0.213)
Avg. Elderly Cert. Period			0.000117 (0.000782)		0.000312 (0.000675)	
Time since Certification	0.0000948 (0.000653)	0.00124 (0.00132)				
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period				0.00576 (0.00478)		0.00348 (0.00294)
Non-Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	-0.00967* (0.00492)		-0.00962 (0.0110)		-0.00966* (0.00492)	
Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)		-0.00427 (0.00562)		-0.00798 (0.0110)		-0.00311 (0.00610)
ESAP (lag)		-0.0128 (0.00738)		0.0308* (0.0123)		-0.00687 (0.00897)
Unemployment Rate (lag)	0.183 (0.256)	0.00663 (0.252)	0.689 (0.422)	1.140* (0.563)	0.171 (0.256)	0.124 (0.265)
HH Size	0.0517*** (0.00791)	0.0183*** (0.00154)	0.0523*** (0.00825)	0.0175*** (0.00152)	0.0517*** (0.00793)	0.0183*** (0.00155)
Working Poor	0.103*** (0.0124)	0.131*** (0.00840)	0.104*** (0.0125)	0.131*** (0.00796)	0.103*** (0.0124)	0.131*** (0.00843)
Constant			0.0253 (0.0370)	-0.169 (0.107)		
Observations	45383	69732	45383	69732	45383	69732
KP rk Wald F-stat (excluded instrument)	95.59	25.23	115.0	24.34	83.53	64.42
Underidentification Test p-value	0.0164	0.0506	0.0000204	0.000310	0.00694	0.0228

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 10: Second Stage Estimates for the Case Error Rate for Non-Elderly/Disabled Households (State-Quarter Level)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	Primary Spec.	No ESAP Control	ESAP Timetrend	ESAP as Additional Instrument	ESAP as Only Instrument
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)	0.298* (0.148)	0.00890 (0.180)	0.196 (0.158)	0.0547 (0.181)	-0.431 (0.287)
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period	0.00232 (0.00219)	-0.000539 (0.00221)	0.000994 (0.00206)	-0.0000461 (0.00223)	-0.00528 (0.00402)
Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	0.00422 (0.00861)	0.00311 (0.00780)	0.00859 (0.00755)	0.00369 (0.00782)	-0.00249 (0.0109)
ESAP (lag)	0.0226** (0.00838)				
ESAP Timetrend(lag)			0.00299** (0.00108)		
Unemployment rate (lag)	-0.375 (0.333)	-0.290 (0.418)	-0.263 (0.334)	-0.306 (0.408)	-0.132 (0.560)
<i>N</i>	601	601	601	601	601
KP rk Wald F-stat (excluded instrument)	30.26	25.07	34.18	16.37	8.850
Underidentification Test p-value	0.0469	0.00389	0.00189	0.0124	0.0295
Overidentification Test p-value				0.0410	

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 11: Second Stage Estimates for the Probability of Payment Error for Non-Elderly/Disabled Households(Case Level)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	Primary Spec.	No ESAP Control	ESAP Timetrend	ESAP as Additional Instrument	ESAP as Only Instrument
Pct. of Cases Recertifying (lag)	0.177 (0.199)	0.326* (0.136)	0.323** (0.122)	0.311* (0.138)	0.624* (0.247)
Avg. Non-Elderly Cert. Period	0.00121 (0.00252)	0.00287 (0.00224)	0.00285 (0.00223)	0.00270 (0.00224)	0.00637* (0.00297)
ESAP (lag)	-0.0123 (0.00802)				
ESAP Timetrend (lag)			-.0000476 (.0010642)		
Elderly Simplified Reporting Pct. (lag)	-0.00445 (0.00572)	-0.00430 (0.00599)	-0.00433 (0.00604)	-0.00445 (0.00598)	-0.00142 (0.00715)
HH Size	0.0183*** (0.00154)	0.0183*** (0.00154)	0.0183*** (0.00154)	0.0183*** (0.00154)	0.0183*** (0.00155)
Unemployment Rate (lag)	0.0247 (0.257)	0.0947 (0.267)	0.0919 (0.261)	0.0868 (0.264)	0.251 (0.360)
Working Poor	0.131*** (0.00840)	0.131*** (0.00842)	0.131*** (0.00843)	0.131*** (0.00842)	0.131*** (0.00846)
Observations	69732	69732	69732	69732	69732
KP rk Wald F-stat (excluded instrument)	37.05	34.80	40.69	21.90	8.156
Underidentification Test p-value	0.0150	0.00177	0.000886	0.00651	0.0269
Overidentification Test p-value				0.129	

Robust standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$